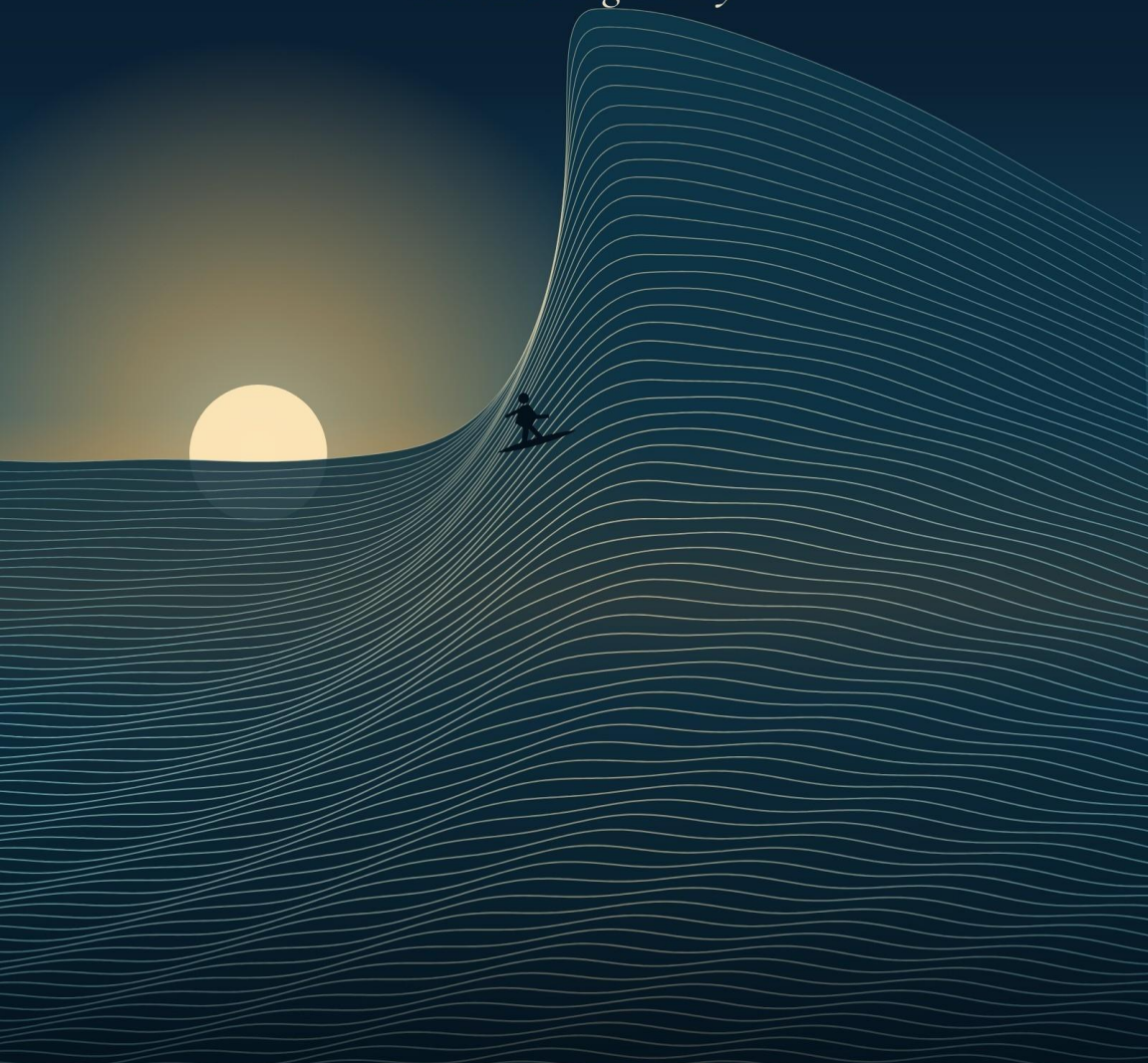
EVOLVING

Riding the AI Wave into the Singularity



RON TAYLOR

executiveclass.ca

Evolving

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RON TAYLOR

An Executive Class Series by Ron Taylor
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An Executive Class Series by Ron Taylor

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A Note on the Stories

The people in this book are drawn from many years of lessons with Brazilian professionals. To protect their privacy, names and identifying details have been changed, and several of the stories combine the experiences of more than one person. Where the book describes research, it says so, and where it describes my own observations as a teacher, it says that too.

Introduction — The Same Wave

Two engineers

Helena landed in Vancouver on a grey morning in February, with two children, four suitcases and a civil engineering degree from the University of São Paulo. In Brazil, she had led teams on large infrastructure projects. People called her *engenheira* with respect. Within a month in Canada, she had learned that her degree needed to be assessed, her experience was "not Canadian" and her English, which had seemed excellent at home, suddenly felt slow and clumsy in fast conversations. For the first time in twenty years, she did not know how to answer the question: *What do you do?*

On the same morning, more than ten thousand kilometres away, her former colleague Paulo sat at his desk in São Paulo. He had not moved anywhere. He had the same job, the same title and the same office he had had for a decade. But that morning, he watched an AI tool produce in a few minutes a set of calculations and a draft report that would once have taken him most of a week. He stared at the screen for a long time. Then he asked himself, quietly, a question he had never asked before: *What now?*

Helena had crossed a continent. Paulo had not left his chair. But both had lost the same thing: **the context that held their identity in place.** The ground under their professional lives had moved, and with it, the easy answer to *Who am I?*

But there was one important difference between them. **Helena chose her disruption.** She decided to leave, prepared for years and accepted the losses in advance as the price of something she wanted for her children. **Paulo's**

disruption was imposed. Nobody asked him. It simply arrived at his desk one morning.

Disruption, chosen or imposed, breaks open the picture we have of ourselves. What happens next is not guaranteed. Some people never fully recover what they lost. Some rebuild exactly what they had. Some discover parts of themselves the old label never showed. What we discover, what we practise, the support we receive and the choices actually open to us all make a difference. This book cannot change the conditions you face. It can help you make the most of the room you have.

This book is about that moment, and about what comes after it.

The same wave

The AI wave is enormous, and it is moving fast. It is changing how people work in almost every field, from offices to hospitals, from classrooms to warehouses. It arrives in Vancouver and São Paulo at the same time.

You can see it as a tsunami, a force of destruction to run from. Many headlines do. But this book offers a different image.

The same wave is a disaster to the person standing on the beach, and the ride of a lifetime to the surfer who paddled out to meet it.

The wave does not decide which experience you have. Your stance, your preparation and your willingness to learn decide. That is the central idea of this book, and everything in it is designed to help you become the surfer.

Why I wrote this book

For many years I have taught Brazilian professionals, one to one and online. Most of them live in Vancouver; some are still preparing to move. They are doctors, engineers, lawyers, managers and entrepreneurs. Our lessons are about English, but they are rarely only about English. They are about job

interviews, networking, first jobs in a new country and the long work of rebuilding a professional life.

I am Canadian, and I have spent three decades working in communication, with students from around the world. Living and working in other cultures taught me something my students learn in their first months in Canada: what it feels like when your words, and your title, no longer work the way they did at home.

Over those years, I have watched some of my students rebuild their lives with remarkable speed, and others stay stuck for a long time. When I asked myself what made the difference, the answer was not intelligence, talent or even English level. **The people who came through stronger saw more of themselves than a label.** When their title did not travel with them, they did not conclude that they had lost themselves. They wanted something more, they were used to achieving goals, they took calculated risks, they did not simply follow the herd, and they never stopped learning.

Then AI arrived, and I realized something. What my students had been going through, the loss of a professional identity and the struggle to rebuild it, was about to happen to millions of people who had never left home. My students were not behind. In many ways, **they were ahead.** They had already learned, the hard way, many of the lessons everyone now needs. That is my observation from years of teaching, not a proven research finding, and this book will try to be clear about the difference.

This book is my attempt to share those lessons: with my students, with every newcomer building a life in a new country, and with anyone, anywhere, who feels the ground moving under their work.

What this book is, and what it is not

Before we begin, a few promises.

AI is not the villain of this book. It may be the most powerful tool for learning, creating and thinking that human beings have ever had. When

things go wrong with AI, the cause is often how it is used, measured or imposed, though the technology has real flaws too: it can be confidently wrong, biased or flattering, as Chapter 7 shows. This book is excited about what AI makes possible, and it will show you how to use it well.

This is not a motivational self-help book. It will not tell you that you are secretly a genius, or that positive thinking will solve your problems. It is based on real experience and on research, and when the research is uncertain, it will tell you so.

This is not a technical manual. You will not learn how to use one particular AI product, because products change every few months. You will learn something more lasting: how to think, learn and grow alongside any of them.

This book will be honest about how hard things are. Not everyone has the same resources, time or opportunities. Migration involves real loss. Individual effort matters, but so does support. You will not be blamed for difficulties that are not your fault.

And one more promise. This book respects the reason most newcomers came to Canada: **a safe place to raise their children and a land of opportunities.** Nothing in it will ask you to risk that. Everything in it is designed to help you protect it.

The journey ahead

The book follows four moves, in four parts:

- **Part I, The Incomplete Self,** looks at what we defend: why there is no safe harbour for a career anymore, why we confuse ourselves with our labels, and why a disruption we did not choose can make us hold on to the old self even harder.
- **Part II, Questioning the Self,** is about discovery: the gifts we take for granted, the people who act as our mirrors, and how AI can become an honest challenger instead of a flatterer.

- **Part III, Developing the Self,** turns to growth: small bets, becoming a beginner again, building capability instead of only borrowing it, and creating beyond the label.
- **Part IV, Remaining Responsible,** is about choice: keeping your own judgment when you work beside AI, building a life larger than a job, and the networks that help us ride.

How to use this book

Each chapter ends with a **lab**: a short, practical exercise that turns the chapter's ideas into action. Some use AI; some use a notebook and a conversation with a real person. Many take less than an hour; a few run over several weeks.

You can read the book straight through and do the labs later. But I encourage you to try at least some of them as you go. Understanding the wave is useful. Getting into the water is what changes you.

The book's argument is simple to state. People may be defending an incomplete understanding of who they are. AI gives them new ways to question that understanding, discover overlooked capabilities and develop possibilities they have never explored. But they must remain responsible for their own thinking and choices.

Throughout the book, one question will return again and again. It is the question at the heart of everything that follows:

Underneath the label, who are you, and who could you become?

We should not allow what we have already become to determine everything we might become.

The wave is already here. Let's paddle out.

Part I — The Incomplete Self

Chapter 1 — No Safe Harbour

The day you landed

You probably remember it well.

The long flight. The tired children. The suitcases that held a whole life, folded small enough to fit under the weight limit. The first breath of cool Pacific air outside the airport, and the strange feeling of standing in a country that did not know your name.

You did not come for adventure. Most people don't. You came for something simpler and much more important: **a safe place to raise your children, and a land of opportunities.** You wanted them to grow up without fear. You wanted doors to open for them, and for you.

That is a good reason to cross a continent. Nothing in this book will tell you otherwise.

But if you have been here for a while, you already know something the brochures did not mention. Arriving in a safe place is not the same as finding the opportunities you came for. The place may be safe. The ground under your career is still moving.

And now a second wave is arriving: artificial intelligence. It is changing the work you came here to do, in the city you chose, while you are still learning the language and finding your feet.

This chapter is about both waves. It is also about the most important lesson immigrants learn, often the hard way, and the one everyone else is about to learn too: **there is no safe harbour for a career anymore.** And that, as we will see, is not the end of safety. It is the beginning of a new kind.

The crisis nobody warned you about

Before we talk about AI, we need to be honest about something. Even without any technology at all, immigrants face a real identity crisis.

It arrives in small moments. The job interview where you understand the question but cannot find the words to show who you really are. The résumé full of achievements that nobody here recognizes. The polite question about "Canadian experience," which you cannot have until someone gives you a chance to get it. The day you introduce yourself and realize you have no simple answer to *What do you do?*

And it arrives at home, too.

Your children adapt quickly. Within months they speak English with a Vancouver accent, have friends you have never met and feel at home in a way you do not yet. You are proud of them. You are also, sometimes, a little lost. You are the one struggling with the language now. Sometimes your child translates for you, and the roles feel reversed.

And far away, in Brazil, are your own parents. You speak on video calls. You worry about their health. You miss the Sunday lunches, the help with the children, the simple comfort of being near the people who raised you. Many of my students have told me that they cried for three months after arriving in Canada, because they missed their families so much.

None of this means you made the wrong choice. It means you are doing something very hard. You are rebuilding a whole life, including the part of you that answers the question *Who am I?*

Psychologists who study migration have a careful name for this: the stress of adapting to a new culture. You might simply call it the hardest years of your life. Either way, it is real, and it deserves respect. This book will not pretend it is easy.

The second wave

While you are still riding the first wave, the second one is already here.

Walk through downtown Vancouver and you pass the offices of some of the largest technology companies in the world. Amazon alone has more than 10,000 workers in British Columbia, including large corporate and technology teams in Vancouver working on things like customer experience, web development and AI itself. In late 2025, more than 1,000 Amazon employees signed an open letter warning that the company's AI rollout was moving too fast. Some workers fear that if they fall behind, they could be next when jobs are cut.

It is worth being careful here. Not every job cut is caused by AI. When Amazon announced global layoffs, Amazon's CEO said the cuts were mainly about culture and removing layers of management, not about AI. Some observers remain skeptical. And the workers who spoke out were clear that they were not against AI itself. Their concern was how quickly and how carelessly it was being introduced.

The wider picture is calmer than the headlines. In a May 2025 update, the International Labour Organization studied nearly 30,000 work tasks and estimated that about one in four workers worldwide is in a job with some exposure to generative AI. But it concluded that most of those jobs are more likely to be transformed than eliminated, because they still need people. Only a small share of jobs face the highest level of exposure.

But there is one thing about this wave that is truly different: **its speed.**

The internet changed the world gradually. It took many years to move from universities into offices, and then into homes and phones. People had time to watch it coming, to learn slowly and to adjust their careers over a decade or more.

AI is moving much faster. When ChatGPT was released at the end of 2022, analysts at UBS estimated it reached about 100 million monthly users in just two months, making it, at the time, the fastest-growing consumer app in history. By comparison, TikTok took about nine months to reach that number, and Instagram about two and a half years. Since then, new tools have appeared not every few years but every few months. Skills that felt advanced last year can feel ordinary today.

That speed changes the strategy. With a slow wave, you can wait in the harbour and decide later. With a fast one, there is no time to wait, and nowhere to hide. You cannot stay in the harbour and hope it passes. You have to paddle out. The people who do best will not be the ones who learned everything about AI. They will be the ones who learned how to keep learning, quickly, again and again.

Into the singularity

The title of this book uses a word you may have heard: *the singularity*. It comes from the mathematician and science-fiction writer Vernor Vinge. In a 1993 essay, he argued that once machines become more intelligent than people, technology could begin to improve itself faster than humans can follow. After that point, he wrote, the future would become impossible to predict. The inventor Ray Kurzweil later made the idea famous in his book *The Singularity Is Near* (2005), and he has predicted that it will arrive around 2045.

Nobody knows whether the singularity will come, or when. Some serious researchers believe machines that match human intelligence across the board could arrive within years. Others think the idea belongs closer to science fiction than to science. This book does not take a side, because its advice does not depend on the answer.

If AI keeps improving at today's speed, the ground under every career will keep moving, and the people who do best will be those who know who they are beneath the label and keep learning. If AI one day surpasses us, those same qualities will matter even more. Your judgment, your values, your relationships and your willingness to begin again are things no machine can live for you. And if the singularity never comes, you will still have built a self that is ready for whatever does.

That is what riding the wave into the singularity means in this book. It is not about predicting the future. It is about becoming someone who can meet it.

So AI is not a monster arriving to take everyone's work. It is a wave: enormous energy, moving fast, changing the shape of the coast. Some tasks will disappear. Many will change. New ones will probably appear, and many of them will still need people.

The question is how. And the surprising answer is that you may already know more about it than most people born here.

Everyone becomes an immigrant

Here is the central idea of this chapter: **AI is doing to many professions what emigration did to you.**

When you moved to Canada, you lost the context that held your professional identity in place. Your expertise did not disappear. But it no longer spoke for itself. You had to explain it, translate it, prove it, and sometimes learn parts of it again.

AI does the same thing to people who never leave home. A lawyer, an accountant, a designer or a programmer can wake up one morning and find that tasks which defined their expertise can now be done by a machine in minutes. Their skills are still real. But the context has changed, and they must explain, translate and prove their value again.

In both cases, the loss happens on three levels:

- **Practical.** *How will I earn a living?* Income, credentials and career paths are suddenly uncertain.
- **Psychological.** *Am I still good at what I do?* Confidence and status are shaken.
- **Existential.** *Who am I now?* The answer that work used to provide no longer fits.

Most people facing AI are meeting these questions for the first time. You have met them already. You have lived through all three, in a new language, while caring for a family.

That does not make it easy to face them again. But it does mean you have practised the hardest skills this new wave will demand: translating your experience, being a beginner again, building a new network and keeping going when your identity is uncertain. **You have already survived one loss of context. That is not a weakness on your résumé. It is training.**

Chosen and imposed

There is one important difference between your two waves.

You chose the first one. Nobody forced you to leave Brazil. You weighed the risks, prepared, saved, said your goodbyes and accepted that you would lose things along the way: your title, your language, your closeness to family. Those losses still hurt. But they were part of a bargain you made, for a reason you believed in.

Nobody chose the second one. AI arrived without asking. It changes the work of people who never wanted change, who were happy where they were, who had just finished rebuilding their careers.

That difference shapes how people respond. When people choose a disruption, they usually meet it with a plan and a purpose. When a disruption is forced on them, they often meet it with resistance. They defend the old self harder, precisely because they never agreed to lose it.

This is why immigrants have something important to teach. You know what it feels like to choose a disruption. And as this book will argue, the most powerful thing a person can do when change is forced on them is to **turn an imposed disruption into a chosen one**. You cannot choose whether the wave comes. You can choose what you do with it.

Fragile, resilient, antifragile

The writer Nassim Nicholas Taleb, in his 2012 book *Antifragile*, described three ways that things respond to shocks. His ideas come from philosophy and risk, not from psychology experiments, but they offer a useful way to think about people. This book applies his idea to personal change. It is a lens for seeing what happens to us, not a scientific test that sorts people into three types.

- **Fragile** things break. A person whose whole identity is their label may break when the label is taken away.
- **Resilient** things bounce back to their old shape. A resilient person survives the shock and rebuilds exactly the self they had before.
- **Antifragile** things grow stronger from shocks. An antifragile person uses the disruption to discover more of who they are, and comes out larger than before.

Resilience is valuable. But this book is about something more: not just surviving the loss of the label, but discovering what the label was hiding. That is what you will meet again and again in the chapters ahead, starting with a doctor in a warehouse.

One caution: nobody should romanticize hardship. People grow from disruptions they can survive and recover from, usually with support from others. Disruption alone does not make anyone stronger. What we do with it, and who helps us, makes the difference.

No safe harbour

There is a lesson sailors learn about tsunamis, and it is not what most people expect.

When a tsunami is coming, the instinct is to hurry into the harbour. The harbour looks safe. It is protected, familiar and close to land. But the harbour

is one of the most dangerous places to be. As the wave reaches shallow water, it slows down and rises up. It crashes into the shore, and the harbour takes the full force.

Out in deep water, something very different happens. The same wave passes underneath a ship as a gentle swell. Sailors who have enough warning are often advised to do the opposite of their instinct: leave the harbour and head for deep water.

Think about what that means for your working life.

For generations, people looked for a safe harbour in their careers: a stable employer, a respected profession, a title that would protect them until retirement. That harbour felt like safety. For many people it still does.

But when a wave like AI arrives, the old harbours are exactly where the damage happens. The job that never changed, the skill that was never updated, the label that was never questioned: these are the places that take the full force of the wave.

So let us be precise about what this book means by "no safe harbour."

- **A safe place to live is real, and worth seeking.** Canada can offer your family that. Your decision to come here for your children's future was not naive.
- **A predictable career is no longer guaranteed anywhere.** Not in Brazil, not in Canada, not at Amazon, not in any profession. No country, employer or title can promise that the ground will not move.

This is not a reason for fear. It is simply the truth about the water we are all in now.

Safety moves from the place to the person

If there is no safe harbour, where is safety?

The answer is the central promise of this book: **safety has moved from the place to the person.** It no longer lives mainly in the job, the employer or the title. It lives in what you carry with you:

- **Your capabilities:** what you can actually do, not just what your title says.
- **Your ability to learn:** how quickly you can become good at something new.
- **Your judgment:** your ability to think clearly, question and decide.
- **Your relationships:** the people who help you learn, take risks and recover.
- **Your sense of who you are:** an identity that does not depend on any single label.

None of these can be left behind at an airport. None of them can be cancelled in a company announcement. They come with you into every new job, every new country and every new wave.

This is also the best answer to the reason you came. If you want to give your children real opportunities in an unpredictable world, the most reliable way is not to find the one place that will never change. There is no such place. It is to become someone who can adapt, and to raise children who can too.

There is something freeing in this idea. If no place is completely safe, then no place can take your safety away either, as long as you build it in yourself.

You have already started. You crossed a continent, learned in a new language and began again. Now the task is to do it deliberately, and to use what may be the most powerful learning tool ever created to help you.

The wave is coming either way, and it is coming fast. Hiding in the harbour is no longer an option. Surfers have a phrase for the moment they leave the shore and push through the breaking water to meet the waves: they paddle out. That is what this book asks you to do. The question is simple: **will you meet it in the harbour, or in deep water?**

Lab 1 — The Task Audit

Time: about one hour. **You need:** a notebook or spreadsheet, and access to an AI assistant.

The first step in meeting any wave is to see it clearly, without panic and without denial.

Step 1 — List your tasks. Write down ten to fifteen tasks that make up your current work, or the work you want to do in Canada. Be specific: not "accounting," but "preparing monthly reports," "answering client questions," "checking invoices."

Step 2 — Mark each task. Next to each one, write:

- **A** if AI already does or helps with this task today;
- **B** if AI may affect it in the next few years;
- **C** if it depends mostly on human judgment, relationships or physical presence.

Step 3 — Ask AI for a second opinion. Share your list with an AI assistant and ask: *"Which of these tasks are most likely to change because of AI, and why? What am I missing?"* Note where it agrees and disagrees with you.

Step 4 — Check against reality. AI's answer is a starting point, not the truth. Talk to one person who works in your field in Vancouver, or read one recent, reliable report about your industry. Adjust your marks.

Step 5 — Look underneath. For each task marked A or B, ask: *What capability does this task use?* Write it down. You will need this list in Chapter 2.

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You may finish this lab feeling uneasy. That is normal. Seeing the wave clearly is uncomfortable, but it is the only way to prepare for it.

Remember what you have already done. You left one harbour and crossed a continent to give your family a better future. You are not standing on the beach. You are already in the water.

Now it is time to paddle out.

Chapter 2 — The Label and the Person

The doctor in the warehouse

In Brazil, people called him *Doutor*.

They said it at the hospital, in the corridors, at the bakery near his apartment. His patients said it with respect. His mother said it with pride. For years, the word arrived before he did. When he walked into a room, people already knew who he was.

Then Marcéu moved to Vancouver.

Nobody here called him *Doutor*. His medical degree was real, but in Canada it was not yet enough to let him practise. The process to have his credentials recognized would take time, money and exams, and his family needed an income now. So he did what many newcomers do. He took the job that was available.

The job was in an Amazon warehouse.

It began out of necessity. He did not choose it because it was his dream. He chose it because his family needed to eat, pay rent and build a life in a new country. In the first weeks, he felt almost invisible. He wore a safety vest instead of a white coat, and nobody asked his opinion about anything. Many people in his position feel something close to shame: the sense that they have fallen, that the years of study were wasted, that the person they were has disappeared.

But something unexpected happened. Marcéu grew into the work. He paid attention. He solved problems. People began to come to him. In time he became a manager, and today he is highly respected at Amazon.

And along the way, he discovered a part of himself he had never known was there. He discovered that he was not only a healer of patients. He was a leader of people.

This is a strange thing to say about a doctor. Here is a man who spent years training for one of the most respected professions in the world. Surely he already knew who he was. Surely his identity was settled.

It was settled. That was the problem.

As long as he was *Doutor*, there was no reason to look any further. The title answered every question. It was only when the title was taken away that Marcéu found out there was more to him than the label had ever shown.

This chapter is about that label, and about the person underneath it.

"What do you do?"

Think about the last time you met someone new. Within a few minutes, one of you probably asked the question: *What do you do?*

It seems like a simple question about work. But we rarely answer it that way. We don't say, "I do engineering." We say, "I *am* an engineer." We don't say, "I practise medicine." We say, "I *am* a doctor."

That small word, *am*, carries a lot of weight. It turns a description of what we do into a statement of who we are.

This is how a job title becomes a label, and how a label becomes a self. It happens slowly, over years, without our noticing. First the title describes our work. Then it organizes our days, our friendships and our plans. Eventually it becomes the answer we give, even to ourselves, when we ask who we are.

It happens most to achievers. If you worked hard for your title, if you studied for years, passed difficult exams and earned the respect of your

colleagues, the title is not just a word. It is proof of everything you have done. Letting go of it can feel like letting go of your own history.

In Brazil, professional titles often carry special social weight. People address lawyers and doctors as *Doutor* or *Doutora*. An engineer is introduced as *engenheiro*. Titles open doors, signal status and earn respect from people you have never met. That makes the label very useful. It also makes it very easy to confuse with the person wearing it.

There is nothing wrong with being proud of your profession. The problem begins when the label stops being something you *have* and becomes something you *are*. Because then, when the label is threatened, it feels as if you are threatened.

What the label gives us

We do not hold on to our labels because we are foolish. We hold on to them because they give us a great deal.

The social psychologist Marie Jahoda spent much of her career studying what happens to people when they lose their jobs. She noticed that work gives us much more than money. It gives our days a shape. It connects us to other people. It gives us goals larger than ourselves. It tells us we have a place in society. And it keeps us active.

A professional label brings all of these together and adds one more gift: an instant answer. When someone asks who you are, the label replies for you. You don't need to explain. You don't need to prove anything. The title does the work.

Think about everything that answer contains:

- **Status.** The title tells others how much respect you have earned.
- **Belonging.** It places you in a group: doctors, engineers, teachers.
- **Certainty.** It tells you what to do next, what success looks like and how to measure yourself.

• **Safety.** As long as the label holds, your future seems predictable.

That last gift matters most to many readers of this book. Most immigrants did not leave home for adventure. They left looking for a safe place to raise their children and a land of opportunities. A respected professional label feels like part of that safety. It feels like solid ground.

So when the label is lost, we lose much more than a word. We lose status, belonging, certainty and, it seems, safety itself, all at once. No wonder it hurts.

The day the label disappears

For immigrants, the label often disappears at the airport.

You leave Brazil as an engineer, a lawyer, a manager, a doctor. You arrive in Canada as a newcomer. Your degree is still in your suitcase, but it does not open the same doors. Employers ask about "Canadian experience." Professional bodies ask for exams and documents. People you meet ask what you do, and you are not sure how to answer.

This is not just a feeling. Statistics Canada reports that in 2024 and 2025, about one in four immigrants with a postsecondary education said they were overqualified for their job, compared with fewer than one in five Canadian-born workers. Among recent arrivals, it was about one in three. Behind those numbers are thousands of people like Marcéu, carrying skills their new country does not yet see.

Now think of a different person. He has never left his city. He has worked in the same field for twenty years. Then AI arrives in his industry, and tasks that once defined his expertise can now be done in minutes. Nobody takes his title away. But the title begins to mean less, and he can feel the ground move.

These two people are living the same experience in different forms. Both are asking the question that a label is supposed to answer: *Who am I now?*

The immigrant has one advantage. The loss is impossible to ignore. It happens all at once, at the border, and it forces a response. The worker facing

AI can tell himself, for a while, that nothing has really changed. That makes his crisis slower, quieter and, in some ways, more dangerous.

For many of the readers of this book, it is both at once. You arrived in Vancouver and lost your label. Now, while you are still building a new one, AI is changing the work you are trying to enter.

The four layers beneath the label

Listen to two people describe the same career.

The first says: *"I am a mechanical engineer. I have twenty-five years of experience designing industrial systems."*

The second says: *"I have spent twenty-five years understanding complex systems, spotting risks before they become problems, coordinating specialists and making decisions when the consequences matter."*

It could be the same person. But the first description stops at the label. The second goes underneath it. If AI changes industrial design, the first person has lost his identity. The second has a list of places to start looking.

A useful way to see this is to think of identity in four layers.

1. **The role.** Your job title, your employer, your position. This is the label, the layer everyone sees first.
2. **Your capabilities.** What you can actually do. The problems you solve, the patterns you notice, the skills you have built and the ways you naturally approach a challenge.
3. **Your values.** What matters to you. The standards you hold yourself to, the responsibilities you accept, the kind of work you are proud of.
4. **The person.** Who you are in your relationships, your curiosity, your character, your faith, your family and your life beyond work.

The role is the top layer, and it is the most fragile. It depends on a particular employer, a particular country, a particular technology. It can disappear at the airport or in a single company announcement.

The other three layers travel much better. They came with Marcéu through the airport. They stay with a worker when AI changes his job. They are what you bring, not just what you did.

When the label is fused with the self, the top layer hides the others. We forget they are there. Losing the label then feels like losing everything, because it was the only layer we were looking at.

This is what makes a person fragile, in the sense of Chapter 1. If the label is the only layer we can see, then losing it breaks us. And it is why so many people, when the label is threatened, defend it so fiercely: they are not defending a job title. They are defending the only version of themselves they know. Marcéu's story is the story of someone who, once the label was gone, found the other layers still there.

What Marcéu carried

When Marcéu walked into the warehouse, his title stayed outside. Everything else came in with him.

Think about what years of medicine build in a person.

- **Calm under pressure.** A doctor learns to think clearly when others are panicking.
- **Diagnosis.** A doctor learns to look at symptoms, ask the right questions and find the real cause of a problem, not just the obvious one.
- **Care for people.** A doctor learns to see the person in front of them, to listen, and to make them feel taken seriously.
- **Responsibility.** A doctor learns that decisions have consequences, and accepts them.
- **Learning.** A doctor never stops studying, because medicine never stops changing.

None of these appear on a warehouse job description. All of them are exactly what a good manager needs. A busy operation is full of problems to diagnose,

people under pressure and decisions that matter. Marcéu was not starting from zero. He was bringing the deeper layers of his identity into a new setting, where nobody had told him they were valuable.

But the story is not only about transfer. Marcéu did not simply reuse old skills. In the warehouse, he discovered something new. He found he had a gift for leading teams: for taking tired, stressed workers on a difficult shift and making them feel calm, organized and taken seriously, and for bringing out the best in people who had never been led well before. As a doctor, he had never needed this part of himself, so he had never found it.

This is the most hopeful idea in this chapter. Losing the label does not only reveal what you already had. It can also make room for parts of you that the label never let you see.

A loss is still a loss

It would be easy to tell Marcéu's story as a simple success: doctor loses title, finds himself, everyone is happy. That would not be honest, and it would not be fair to readers living through the same thing.

So let us be clear.

A trained doctor working outside medicine is a loss. It is a loss for him, who spent years preparing. It is a loss for his new country, which needs doctors. The difficulty of having foreign credentials recognized in Canada is real, and it affects thousands of skilled newcomers. This chapter does not suggest that doctors belong in warehouses, or that anyone should be grateful for being underemployed.

If you are living this now, your frustration is not a weakness. Your grief for the title you lost is not vanity. It is a natural response to losing something you worked hard to earn.

And for some people, it does not feel like a loss at all.

Many immigrant parents make a clear, deliberate choice: they will give up the title if it means their children are safe and thriving. They watch their son

make friends at school, their daughter grow confident in a new language, the family sleep peacefully at night, and they decide the trade was worth it. My students tell me this again and again: when they see their children thriving in Canada, they know they made the right decision. It pays dividends every day.

That is not a defeat, and it is not a person trapped by circumstances. It is the four layers working exactly as they should. These parents have looked beneath the label and found something that matters more to them: their values, and the person they are as a mother or father. They let the top layer go because a deeper one was more important.

If that is your choice, this book honours it completely. Nothing in the chapters ahead asks you to chase a title for its own sake. What it asks is that you keep growing, for yourself and for the children who are watching you.

The point of Marcéu's story is different. It is not that the loss didn't matter. It is that **the loss of the title was not the loss of the person.** His identity and his abilities survived. They even grew. The label was taken away; Marcéu was not.

Both things can be true at the same time. You can grieve the label and still discover who you are without it.

AI and the label

Why does all this matter more now?

Because AI works mostly on the top layer. It changes tasks. It can draft the report, analyze the data, write the code, translate the document. Those tasks are often what our job titles were built around. When they change, the label begins to shift, even if nobody takes it away.

As we saw in Chapter 1, the International Labour Organization expects most jobs exposed to generative AI to be transformed rather than eliminated, because people are still needed. So far, for most people, the wave is changing work more than erasing it. But early evidence suggests entry-level roles in highly exposed fields may be shrinking, so it is wise to watch your field closely.

That is why the deeper layers matter so much. Your capabilities, your values and the person you are can move with you as the work changes. They are what let you ride the wave instead of being knocked over by it.

One honest warning: capabilities can also become outdated. There is no part of you that is guaranteed to be "AI-proof." The goal is not to find a permanent identity that nothing can touch. It is to understand yourself well enough that you can keep learning, adapting and finding new places to bring what you have.

And here is the good news. AI is not only a force that changes the label. It can also help you look underneath it. Later in this book, you will learn to use AI as an honest mirror: describing your experience, asking it to find patterns, and discovering strengths your label has hidden. You will also learn why you must never let AI hand you a new label to wear. The deeper layers are yours to discover. AI can help you look; only you can decide what is true.

Lab 2 — Two Descriptions

Time: 30–45 minutes. **You need:** a notebook, and one person who knows you well.

Step 1 — The label. Write a short description of yourself using only your job title, qualifications and work history. This is the version you would give at a party.

Step 2 — Underneath the label. Write a second description without naming your job, your employer or your degree. Describe what you bring, starting from the capabilities you listed in Lab 1: the problems you solve, what people come to you for, what you care about, how you work.

Step 3 — The four layers. Under each heading below, write three things about yourself:

- Role
- Capabilities

- Values
- Person

Notice which layer was easiest to fill and which was hardest. The hardest is usually the one your label has been hiding.

Step 4 — Ask AI. Give an AI assistant your second description and ask: *"What patterns do you see in this? What capabilities might I be overlooking? What evidence would you need to be sure?"* Treat its answer as a list of ideas to test, not as the truth about you.

Step 5 — The real test. Show both descriptions to someone who knows you well. Ask which one sounds more like you, and what is missing from both.

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Marcéu is still a doctor. Nothing can take away what he learned, what he knows or the years he spent caring for patients. But he has learned something many people never discover: that *Doutor* was a title he held, not the whole of who he is.

You have a label too. Perhaps you lost it at the airport. Perhaps AI is starting to loosen it. Perhaps it still fits perfectly, for now.

Whatever your situation, the question is the same. **Underneath the label, who are you?** The rest of this book is about finding out, and about becoming more of that person than you ever expected.

Chapter 3 — Defending the Self We Know

The job he fought for

It took Ricardo three years to get the job.

In São Paulo he had been a senior engineer, the person younger colleagues came to with hard problems. In Vancouver he started again. He took courses at night, rewrote his résumé a dozen times, worked in jobs far below his experience and practised his English until the words came more easily. He was rejected more times than he wants to remember.

And then, finally, the offer came. A good company. A real engineering role. A salary that meant his family could rent a better apartment and stop worrying at the end of every month.

That was four years ago. Today Ricardo is respected at work. He knows the systems better than almost anyone. For the first time since he landed, life feels predictable.

Last spring, his company announced a program to train engineers in new AI tools. Several younger colleagues signed up immediately. Ricardo did not.

"I don't need it," he told his wife. "I know how to do my job. I fought too hard to get here to start being a beginner again."

If you are an immigrant, you probably understand Ricardo very well. After years of struggle, he has finally reached solid ground. Why would he risk it?

But notice something. Ricardo *chose* his first disruption. He decided to come to Canada and accepted everything it cost him. This second disruption,

AI, he did not choose. Nobody asked him. And so the same man who embraced enormous change once is now refusing a much smaller one.

This chapter is about why. It is about the many ways intelligent, hard-working people end up **defending the self they know**, even when that self is incomplete, and even when defending it puts their future at risk.

The achiever's engine

Before we look at what went wrong, let us look at what went right.

Ricardo is not a cautious man by nature. Nobody crosses a continent and rebuilds a career in a second language by playing it safe. To get where he is, Ricardo set hard goals and reached them, again and again.

The Canadian-born psychologist Albert Bandura spent decades studying what he called *self-efficacy*: a person's belief that they can succeed at a task. He found that the strongest source of that belief is not encouragement or positive thinking. It is experience. Every time you succeed at something difficult, you become more confident that you can succeed at the next difficult thing. Bandura called these *mastery experiences*.

Ricardo has a lifetime of them. So, very likely, do you: a language learned as an adult, qualifications earned through years of effort, a frightening decision followed through. These are evidence that you have what this book calls **the achiever's engine**: the drive to want something more, and the habit of getting it.

The engine is still there. The question is what it is pointed at now.

Five ways we defend

Defending the self we know is not one habit. It is several, and they often work together.

1. Achieving becomes maintaining

When you are climbing, your energy goes upward, toward the next goal. Then you arrive somewhere good, and slowly, without deciding to, you turn around. Your energy stops pointing forward and starts pointing back, at what you have, to make sure nobody takes it away. **The habit of achieving becomes a habit of maintaining.**

For immigrants, this is especially understandable. After years of insecurity, a predictable job is proof that the sacrifice was worth it. It is safety for your children. Of course you want to protect it. The problem is not protection itself. The problem is when protection becomes the only thing your ambition does.

2. Expertise hardens

When you become very good at something, you develop habits of thinking that let you see solutions almost instantly. That is what expertise is. But the management scholar Erik Dane described how those same habits can harden into *cognitive entrenchment*, making it harder to adapt when the situation changes. A 2022 review by Ting Zhang, Kelly Harrington and Elad Sherf found that expertise can also make people less likely to seek advice and feedback. Experts can become so sure of what they know that they stop asking.

It is important to be fair here: **experience does not make people less adaptable.** Many experienced professionals adapt brilliantly. The problem is not expertise. It is expertise that has stopped learning, and an identity built on "I am the person who knows."

3. The herd feels safe

In the 1950s, the psychologist Solomon Asch ran a famous series of experiments. He showed people a line and asked which of three other lines matched its length. The answer was obvious. But each participant sat among other people who, secretly working with the researcher, deliberately gave the

wrong answer. Participants went along with the group's obviously wrong answer in roughly a third of the trials, and most conformed at least once.

These were not foolish people. They simply did not want to stand alone. For a newcomer, that pressure is even stronger. You are in a new country, unsure of the rules, hungry to belong. When everyone around you says "just keep your head down" or "don't try anything new until you're settled," following the herd feels like safety. Sometimes it is. But the herd knows the common path, not your path, and it rarely encourages anyone to question who they are.

4. Alone, we hold on tighter

There is a quieter cause of defending, and it is especially common among newcomers: isolation.

When you have few people around you, you also have few mirrors. Nobody shows you another version of yourself. Nobody says, "You know, you'd be good at this." The only picture of you that remains is the old one, the label you brought from home. And so you hold on to it tightly, because it is all you have.

Ricardo works long hours and spends his free time with his family. He has almost no contact with people outside his small team. Nobody in his life has suggested he might be more than the engineer he was in São Paulo. As we will see in Chapter 6, other people are often the ones who show us what we cannot see ourselves. Without them, defending is the natural default.

5. Bouncing back to the old shape

The last way we defend can look like a strength. It is resilience.

In Chapter 1, we saw the difference between resilient people, who bounce back to their old shape after a shock, and antifragile people, who grow stronger and discover more. Resilience is admirable. Ricardo is resilient: he lost his title when he emigrated, and through enormous effort he rebuilt it, almost exactly as it was.

But notice what resilience does not do. It restores the old self. It does not question it. Ricardo never asked whether "senior engineer" was the whole of who he is. He simply worked until he had it back. Now that AI threatens it again, his instinct is the same: hold on, rebuild, restore. **Resilience can become a sophisticated way of defending an incomplete self.**

Why imposed disruption makes us defend harder

All five of these patterns grow stronger when a disruption is forced on us.

Psychologists have a name for one part of this. In the 1960s, Jack Brehm described what he called *psychological reactance*: when people feel their freedom is being taken away, they tend to push back, sometimes holding on even more firmly to the very thing being threatened. People do not like being told they must change.

This helps explain Ricardo. When he chose to emigrate, the losses were his decision. With AI, change is being pressed on him by his company, his industry and the headlines. Part of his refusal is not about AI at all. It is about refusing a bargain he never agreed to.

That is understandable. But it leaves him in a strange position: defending a self that was never complete, against a change he cannot stop, using a strategy that makes him more vulnerable, not less.

Protecting your future, or your image?

Here is a hard question. Take a moment with it before you answer.

When you refuse to learn something new, are you protecting your future, or protecting the image you have of yourself?

Ricardo believes he is protecting his future. But by refusing the new tools, he is making his position *more* vulnerable. His younger colleagues are building skills the company will need. What he is really protecting is the feeling of being the expert: the man who does not have to be a beginner.

It is important not to confuse Ricardo's situation with a different one. Some parents choose stability on purpose. They decide that a secure job, even a modest one, is worth more than any title, because their children are safe and thriving. That is not defending. It is choosing, and it is a wise and loving choice. But even that choice is safest when it includes learning, because the stable job you chose for your children is in the same water as every other job.

Four ways to meet AI

When AI arrives in an expert's field, people tend to respond in one of four ways: they **dismiss** it, protecting their status for a while; they **follow it blindly**, surrendering the judgment that made them valuable; they **withdraw**, out of fear; or they **use it with judgment**, learning what it can and cannot do.

There is encouraging research about the fourth way. In 2025, researchers from Microsoft Research and Carnegie Mellon University surveyed 319 knowledge workers who use AI. People with more confidence in AI tended to think less critically about its answers; people with more confidence in their own abilities tended to think more critically. It was a survey, so it shows an association rather than proof. But it suggests that **your confidence in what you know is exactly what allows you to use AI well**, as long as that confidence makes you curious rather than closed.

Lab 3 — What Am I Defending?

Time: 30–45 minutes. **You need:** a notebook and some quiet.

Step 1 — Your achievement history. Write down five difficult goals you set and reached. Next to each, write what it required of you. Then finish this sentence: *"When I want something, I..."*

Step 2 — The five ways. Read the five ways we defend in this chapter. For each, give yourself an honest score from 0 (not me) to 3 (very much me).

Step 3 — Chosen or imposed? List the biggest changes in your working life. Mark each as *chosen* or *imposed*. Notice how differently you responded to each kind.

Step 4 — The honest question. Write one answer to: *What am I currently protecting, and is it my future or my image?*

Step 5 — One small opening. Choose one area where you have been defending, and one small step to open it: a conversation, a course, a question you have avoided asking.

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Ricardo has not lost anything yet. He is standing in the harbour, telling himself he is safe. But the engine that carried him across a continent is still there, idling.

In the next chapter, we look at how people turn that engine back on: how they take a disruption they did not choose and make it their own.

Chapter 4 — From Imposed to Chosen

Three years later

Ana and Felipe landed in Vancouver in the same month.

On paper, they were almost identical. Both were in their late thirties, with university degrees and more than ten years of experience in Brazil: Ana in marketing, Felipe in finance. Both came with families, savings that would not last forever, and English good enough to get by but not yet good enough to shine. They even met at the same newcomer workshop.

Three years later, their lives look very different.

Ana works for a mid-sized technology company in a role that did not exist when she left Brazil. It combines her marketing experience with data analysis she taught herself in her first year, partly with the help of AI tools. When people ask what she does, she laughs and says her job title changes every year.

Felipe is still waiting. He has applied for dozens of finance positions at his old level and been turned down for most of them. He is angry, and he has reason to be: the system does not recognize what he has done, and that is unfair. But when friends suggest he try something adjacent, or learn a new skill, he shakes his head. "I am a financial manager," he says. "I just need someone here to see it."

Here is what makes their stories interesting. Both of them **chose** to come to Canada. But somewhere along the way, Felipe stopped experiencing his situation as a choice. The rejection, the unfair system, the job he does not talk

about: all of it now feels like something being done to him. Ana, facing the same obstacles, kept treating each one as a decision she could make.

The difference between them is not effort, intelligence or luck. It is whether the disruption still feels chosen.

What immigrants know about choosing

I have taught many Brazilian professionals one to one, most of them in Vancouver, and I have watched some rebuild their lives with remarkable speed while others stay stuck for a long time. The ones who came through stronger shared one quality above all others: **they saw more of themselves than a label.** Around it, I noticed four more: they wanted something more, they were used to achieving goals, they took calculated risks, and they did not simply follow the herd.

But there is something underneath all five, and it took me a long time to see it. These people experienced their migration as **a choice they kept making**, not a single decision they made once and then had to live with.

Think about what choosing a disruption gives you:

- **A reason.** You know why you are doing this. The hardship has a purpose.
- **A plan.** You prepared. You thought about what could go wrong.
- **Accepted losses.** You knew you would lose things, and you accepted the price in advance.
- **Ownership.** When something goes wrong, you ask "what do I do now?" rather than "why is this happening to me?"

That last point is the key. A chosen disruption keeps you in the position of the person deciding. An imposed one puts you in the position of the person things happen to. And as we saw in Chapter 3, people in that second position tend to defend the old self harder.

You cannot choose the wave. You can choose your response.

Most people facing AI did not choose it. Felipe did not choose the unfair way his credentials were treated. Marcéu did not choose the warehouse. Some readers of this book did not even fully choose to emigrate: family pressure, economic necessity or danger at home pushed them out.

So what does it mean to "choose" a disruption you did not ask for?

It does not mean pretending you wanted it. It means making a decision about what you will do with it. Marcéu is the clearest example. He chose Canada, but he did not choose the warehouse. It was imposed by necessity. Yet at some point, he stopped treating the warehouse as something that had happened to him and started treating it as a place where he would decide how to act. He paid attention, solved problems and grew. The circumstances were imposed. The response was chosen.

That shift, from "this is happening to me" to "this is what I choose to do with it," is the hinge of this whole book. It is what turns a resilient person, who simply survives and restores, into an antifragile one, who grows and discovers.

The loop

Why does seeing more than a label make such a difference? Because it changes the price of every risk.

If you believe you are *only* a financial manager, every step outside finance threatens your whole identity. The price is enormous, so you avoid it. But if you see yourself as someone who understands money, solves complex problems, earns trust and learns quickly, a step outside finance puts only one part of you at stake. You can afford it.

So you take the risk, and **taking the risk shows you even more of who you are.** Ana did not know she was good at data analysis until she tried it. The experiment revealed a new capability, which widened her self-image, which made the next risk easier still.

This loop runs in both directions:

- **The widening loop:** a wide self-image makes risk affordable → you take the risk → you discover more of yourself → your self-image grows wider.
- **The narrowing loop:** a narrow self-image makes risk too costly → you avoid it → you discover nothing new → your self-image narrows, and the next risk feels bigger.

Ana is in the first loop. Felipe, through no lack of effort, is in the second. The good news is that a loop can be reversed. It takes one small, safe risk, the kind we will design in Chapter 8, to start turning it the other way.

Writing your own definition

The Harvard psychologist Robert Kegan spent his career studying how adults develop. He described two very different ways of making sense of ourselves.

In the **socialized mind**, our identity comes mainly from outside: from our roles, our groups and the expectations of people who matter to us. We are good at meeting those expectations. But when they change or disappear, we feel lost.

In the **self-authoring mind**, we develop our own inner compass: our own values, standards and sense of direction. We still care what others think, but their opinion is one voice among many, not the final word. Kegan's research suggests that many adults never fully make this shift, and that is not a criticism. The socialized mind works well in a stable world.

But emigration is not a stable world, and neither is AI. When roles change and expectations disappear, the person whose identity comes only from outside has nothing to hold on to. Felipe is waiting for Canada to confirm who he is. Ana decided for herself.

Self-authorship is how an imposed disruption becomes a chosen one. You cannot write the circumstances. But you can write the definition of who you are within them.

Naming your something more

There is a practical way to begin. It is to name what you are moving *toward*.

When I ask my students why they came to Canada, the deepest answer is almost always about their children: a safe place to raise them and a land of opportunities. That is what I call their **something more**: the deep, steady reason that kept them going through the visa applications, the first cold winter and the rejected résumés.

The researchers Edwin Locke and Gary Latham, who developed goal-setting theory, found in many studies that clear, challenging goals help people perform better and persist longer than vague ones. A destination turns hardship into a step toward something.

This is exactly what an imposed disruption takes away. AI rarely removes a whole career at once. More often it removes the **next step**: the visible ladder, the clear goal. And an achiever with no destination stalls. They freeze, maintain, defend.

Naming a new something more gives the disruption a direction. It does not need to be a job title, which may change. It can be security, growth, freedom, contribution, meaning, or, for many readers, a safe place and real opportunities for their children. None of these is better than the others. What matters is that it is yours.

The psychologists Richard Ryan and Edward Deci, who developed self-determination theory, found that goals rooted in growth, relationships and contribution tend to support wellbeing more than goals rooted only in wealth or status. Money still matters, especially for a newcomer family. But ask what the money is *for*, and you will usually find your real something more underneath.

A caution on choosing

Talking about "choosing your response" can sound like blaming people for their circumstances. It is not.

Some readers have very little room to choose: work permits tied to one employer, debts, children to care for alone. Felipe's anger at an unfair system is legitimate. Choosing your response does not mean accepting injustice quietly. Sometimes the chosen response is to fight it, to organize, to demand recognition. The point is not that every situation is fair. It is that, within whatever room you have, **you remain the author.**

And remember the parents in Chapter 2 who gave up a title gladly because their children were safe and thriving. They are self-authored too. They did not let their profession or their country decide what success meant. They chose. Self-authorship does not always mean climbing higher. Sometimes it means knowing exactly what you value, and choosing it freely.

Lab 4 — From "Happened to Me" to "I Chose"

Time: about 45 minutes. **You need:** a notebook and an AI assistant.

Step 1 — Whose definition? Write down five beliefs about who you are and what success means. Next to each, mark where it came from: family, profession, Brazilian society, Canadian society, or me. For each belief that did not come from you, ask: *Would I choose this today?*

Step 2 — Two versions of your story. Write three sentences about your current situation as something that *happened to you*. Then rewrite the same facts as a series of *choices you are making*. Notice how each version feels.

Step 3 — Your something more. Finish these sentences: *"I came to Canada (or chose my path) because…"*, *"In five years, I want…"*, *"I would regret not trying…"*. For each, ask "why does that matter to me?" three times. Write your something more in one sentence, without a job title.

Step 4 — One chosen step. Ask an AI assistant: *"Given this goal and my situation, what is one small step I could choose this month?"* Pick one, and put it in your calendar.

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The end of Part I

Look at what Part I has shown.

There is no safe harbour for a career anymore, and two waves are now reaching our readers at once: the one they chose and the one AI imposes (Chapter 1). Most of us identify with a label that is only the top layer of who we are (Chapter 2). We defend that incomplete self in many ways, from maintaining what we have to bouncing back to our old shape, and we defend hardest when change is forced on us (Chapter 3). And the way out begins with turning an imposed disruption into a chosen one: writing our own definition and naming what we are moving toward (this chapter).

But a chosen direction is not yet a discovery. Felipe could decide tomorrow to stop waiting, and still not know what else he could become. That is the subject of Part II: how we question the incomplete self, and discover what it has been leaving out.

Part II — Questioning the Self

How the hidden self is exposed, and where each mirror misleads.

Chapter 5 — The Gifts We Take for Granted

"Nothing special"

There is a question I like to ask my students, usually in our first few lessons together: *What are you good at?*

The first answer is almost always a job title. "I'm an engineer." "I was a lawyer." "I worked in a bank." Then I change the question: *What do people come to you for?* There is usually a long pause. People look away from the camera. It is a much harder question.

Renata was a nurse in an intensive care unit in Belo Horizonte for fourteen years. In Vancouver, while her credentials were being assessed, she worked as a care aide. When I asked her, in one of our online lessons, what people came to her for, she shrugged. "Nothing special," she said. "I'm just organized."

So I asked her to tell me about her week instead. In a few minutes she described running a household of five people, two jobs and a credential application at the same time. She mentioned, almost in passing, that she had calmly talked a neighbour through what to do when his child had a high fever. And she laughed that whenever her church group planned anything, it was somehow always Renata who quietly made it happen. For homework, I asked her to put the same question to two people who knew her well. Her sister and an old friend from Brazil gave almost the same answer: *you are the person who makes things work.*

It turned out that in Brazil, Renata had also run the scheduling for her entire ward: dozens of nurses, three shifts, constant emergencies. She had never thought of that as a skill. It was just something she did because somebody had to.

"Just organized" was, in fact, a talent for running complex operations under pressure. It had been there for fourteen years. It had never once appeared on her résumé.

This chapter begins the second part of the book, and the most important one. In Part I, we saw why people defend an incomplete understanding of themselves. Now we ask the harder question: **how do we discover what the incomplete version leaves out?**

Why our best gifts hide

You might think that the abilities we are best at would be the easiest to see. Often the opposite is true.

When something is difficult for you, you notice it. You work at it, you struggle, you remember the day you finally mastered it. That effort leaves a mark, and so you can name the skill.

But when something comes naturally, there is no struggle and no mark. You simply do it. And because it feels easy to you, you assume it is easy for everyone. It does not feel like a skill. It feels like "just how I am."

That is why Renata said "nothing special." Her gift was so familiar that it had become invisible. And she is not unusual. Most people can list the things they find hard much more easily than the things they do well without trying.

There is a second reason our gifts hide: **the label decides what counts.** Renata's label was "nurse." Anything that fitted the label, such as clinical knowledge, she recognized as a skill. Anything outside it, such as running a complex schedule, she filed under "just something I did." The label did not only describe her. It decided which parts of her were worth noticing.

The story we keep telling

The psychologist Dan McAdams has spent much of his career studying what he calls *narrative identity*: the story each of us builds about our own life. Where we came from, what happened to us, what it means and where we are going. According to his research, this inner story is not just a description of who we are. In an important sense, it *is* part of who we are. It shapes what we notice, what we remember and what we believe is possible.

That is mostly a good thing. A clear life story gives people meaning and direction. But a story also has a plot, and a plot leaves things out. If your story is "I am a nurse who helps patients," the parts of your life that do not fit that plot fade into the background. You stop telling them. Eventually, you stop noticing them.

This is how a person comes to defend an incomplete understanding of themselves without ever choosing to. Nobody decides to hide their gifts. The story simply has no room for them.

And this is why disruption, painful as it is, can be useful. When emigration or AI breaks the old story, it also breaks the plot that was leaving things out. Suddenly, the question "who am I?" is open again. The parts of you that never fitted the old story have a chance to be seen.

The selves we might become

In 1986, the psychologists Hazel Markus and Paula Nurius published an influential paper called "Possible Selves." Their idea was simple and powerful. Each of us carries not only a picture of who we are now, but also pictures of who we *might* become: the selves we hope for, the selves we expect, and the selves we fear.

These possible selves matter because they guide what we try. A hoped-for self pulls us forward. A feared self pushes us away from certain risks. And a possible self we have never imagined is a direction we will never take.

Think about the possible selves many immigrants carry:

- **The hoped-for self:** settled, respected, the children thriving, the career rebuilt.
- **The expected self:** working hard, perhaps below one's qualifications for a while, slowly climbing.
- **The feared self:** the one who failed, who wasted the family's savings, who has to go back.

That feared self is powerful. It explains a great deal of defending. If your strongest image of the future is the person who failed, then any risk feels like a step toward that person. So you hold on to the label, the safe job, the familiar path, not because they fulfil you, but because they keep the feared self away.

Here is the hopeful part. Possible selves are not fixed. They grow from the people we meet, the examples we see and the experiences we have. Marcéu, in Chapter 2, had never imagined himself as a manager in a large operation. That possible self did not exist for him in Brazil. It only appeared when the old label fell away and a new context showed him something he could become.

This is the real work of Part II: **not only to discover the gifts you already have, but to widen the range of selves you can imagine.**

Disruption as information

In Chapter 1, we met three ways of responding to disruption: the fragile person who breaks, the resilient person who bounces back to the old shape, and the antifragile person who grows stronger and discovers more.

One of the habits of antifragile people is that they treat disruption as **information**. Not only as a threat or a loss, but as evidence about themselves.

Ask yourself what the hardest moments of your migration revealed. When you lost your title, what did you still have? When nothing was familiar, what

did you do well anyway? When you had to start over, what kind of work did you find yourself drawn to, and what kind did you hate?

Those answers are data. They are often more honest than anything you could learn in a comfortable life, because disruption removes the label that usually answers for you. Renata did not discover her gift for running complex operations while she was a respected ICU nurse. She discovered it when she was a care aide, in a new country, being asked by an English teacher what people came to her for.

This is not a romantic view of hardship. Disruption causes real pain, and nobody should have to lose everything to learn about themselves. But if the disruption has already happened, wasting what it reveals would be a second loss.

A caution: not every belief about yourself is wrong

This chapter could be misread as saying that every limit you believe in is false and every hidden gift is waiting to be found. That would be dishonest.

Some of what you believe about yourself is accurate. Some things you find difficult really are difficult for you. Some gifts, once discovered, turn out to be ordinary. And some possible selves are not realistic, at least not now, not without resources you do not have.

The goal is not to replace a pessimistic story with a flattering one. It is to replace an **unexamined** story with an **examined** one. Some beliefs will survive the examination. Others will not. Either way, you will know more about yourself than before.

There are three main ways to examine the story: looking at your own experience, as this chapter has done; asking other people, which we turn to in Chapter 6; and asking AI, with care, which we explore in Chapter 7. Each one sees something the others miss. Each one can also mislead.

A method for discovery

How do you tell a real capability from something you merely enjoy, something you hope is true, or something a flattering friend or machine has told you? For the rest of this book, we will use the same simple method for every possible gift:

1. **Observe.** Notice a pattern: what people come to you for, what feels easy, what a disruption revealed.
2. **Find evidence.** Name specific occasions when it actually happened.
3. **Get confirmation.** Ask other people, separately, whether they see it too (Chapter 6).
4. **Test it.** Try it in a small, real situation and look honestly at the result (Chapters 7 and 8).
5. **Develop it.** If it passes, practise it deliberately until it becomes a strength you can rely on (Part III).

You do not need a hidden genius for this method to work. You only need to look carefully at what you have already shown you can do, and at what you might learn to do next. Some possible gifts will not survive the tests. That is useful too.

Lab 5 — The Gift Inventory

Time: about 45 minutes. **You need:** a notebook and some quiet.

Step 1 — What do people come to you for? List at least eight things people have asked you for help with, in any part of your life: work, family, friends, community. Do not filter. Small things count.

Step 2 — What feels easy? List five things you do that seem easy to you but that you have noticed others find hard.

Step 3 — What did the disruption reveal? Think about the hardest period of your migration, or the moment AI first changed your work. Write down three things you did well even then.

Step 4 — Your possible selves. Write one sentence for each:

- *A self I hope to become:*
- *A self I expect to become:*
- *A self I fear becoming:*

Then ask: how is the feared self shaping the risks I take or avoid?

Step 5 — Find the pattern. Look across all four lists. Circle anything that appears more than once. Those repeated items are candidates for the gifts your label has been hiding. Do not decide yet whether they are real. In the next two chapters, you will test them.

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Renata's gift was there for fourteen years. It took a new country, a teacher on a screen and two honest people who knew her for her to see it.

That is the subject of the next chapter. Because some of the most important truths about ourselves cannot be seen from the inside. We need other people to show them to us.

Chapter 6 — Other People as Mirrors

What a stranger saw

Daniela had been a human resources manager in Porto Alegre. In Vancouver, to improve her English, she joined a conversation program at her local library, where newcomers practise with Canadian volunteers.

Her volunteer partner was a retired woman named Margaret. Every week they talked about ordinary things: the weather, the neighbourhood, the confusing rules for recycling. Daniela often found herself explaining how things worked in Brazil: how families organized themselves, how companies hired people, why certain words had no translation.

After about two months, Margaret said something that stayed with her. "You know," she said, "you are the clearest explainer I have ever met. You take something complicated and make it simple, and you always check that I've understood. Have you ever thought about training people?"

Daniela had not. In Brazil, she had run hiring processes and handled difficult conversations. Training was something other people in her department did. But Margaret's comment made her look back, and she realized that the parts of her old job she had loved most were the moments when she explained things to new employees. She had simply never thought of it as her strength.

Margaret, it turned out, had a nephew who managed a corporate training team. A coffee became an introduction; the introduction became a small contract; the contract became a career. Today Daniela designs training programs for newcomers joining a Vancouver company.

A stranger saw in two months what Daniela had not seen in twenty years. And then the same stranger opened a door.

That is what this chapter is about: **other people as mirrors, and as windows.**

Why others see what we cannot

It seems strange that someone who barely knows you could see something important about you that you have missed. But research suggests it is quite normal.

The psychologist Simine Vazire has studied what she calls the *self–other knowledge asymmetry*. In a 2010 study, she found that we are usually the best judges of our own inner states, such as how anxious we feel, because those are hidden from other people. But for qualities that show up in our behaviour and that carry a strong sense of being good or bad, such as intelligence or creativity, the people around us are sometimes more accurate than we were ourselves.

There are good reasons for this. When we judge ourselves, we are influenced by our hopes, our fears and our labels. We are also too close: we see our own effort, not our effect. Other people see the effect. Margaret did not see how hard Daniela worked to explain things. She simply saw that she understood.

This is why Renata's sister and her old friend, in Chapter 5, could name her gift when she could not. And it is why no amount of private reflection can give you a complete picture of yourself. **Some truths about you are only visible from the outside.**

How to ask

Most of us rarely ask other people what they see in us. It feels awkward, even vain. And when we do ask, we ask badly: *"What do you think of me?"* That question produces polite, vague answers.

Researchers at the University of Michigan developed a better approach, known as the *Reflected Best Self Exercise*. Instead of asking for opinions, it asks people for **stories**: a specific time when you were at your best, and what you did. You collect stories from people in different parts of your life, then look for the patterns across them.

Stories work better than opinions because they contain evidence. "You're very organized" is a compliment. "When our class trip was falling apart, you made three phone calls and fixed it in twenty minutes" is information.

Here are some questions that tend to produce useful answers:

- *"Can you tell me about a time when I helped you, or someone else, in a way that mattered?"*
- *"When have you seen me at my best? What was I doing?"*
- *"What do you come to me for that you don't go to others for?"*
- *"Is there something you think I'm good at that I don't seem to notice?"*

Asking these questions takes some courage, especially in a second language. But in my experience, people are usually glad to be asked. Most of us enjoy telling someone what we admire about them; we simply never get the invitation.

Old mirrors and new ones

Here is something surprising about the people closest to us: they are often the people most likely to keep us the same.

Herminia Ibarra, whose research on career change we will meet again in Chapter 8, noticed this in the professionals she studied. Old friends and

colleagues know the old you. They have a clear picture of who you are, and without meaning to, they hold you to it. When you mention a new idea, they say, "But you're an accountant," or "That doesn't sound like you." They are not trying to limit you. They are describing the person they know.

Ibarra found that people who successfully changed direction usually did so partly by **shifting their connections**: spending time with new people, in new communities, who saw them without the old label and could reflect back the person they were becoming.

This gives the immigrant experience an unexpected meaning. When you emigrated, you lost much of your old network. That is a real loss, and Chapter 14 will take it seriously. But it also means you lost many of the mirrors that held you to your old self. Margaret had never known Daniela the HR manager. She only knew the woman in front of her, the one who explained things so well. **A new country gives you new mirrors.**

The sociologist Mark Granovetter showed, in a famous 1973 paper, that people often hear about new job opportunities through acquaintances rather than close friends. He called this "the strength of weak ties." Close friends move in the same circles and know the same things. Acquaintances connect you to different worlds.

Weak ties are not only windows to opportunity. They are also mirrors. Someone who meets you fresh sees you without your history, and can sometimes see possibilities that everyone who knows your history has stopped noticing.

Double vision

Living between two cultures adds another kind of mirror.

The psychologist John Berry has spent decades studying *acculturation*: what happens to people when they live between their culture of origin and a new one. In his framework, people can hold on only to their original culture, give it up entirely for the new one, or try to keep both. Much of his research

suggests that people who manage to keep both, connected to where they came from and to where they are now, often adapt best. Researchers continue to debate how strong and how universal this pattern is, but the idea is helpful.

Keeping both cultures gives you double vision. Brazilian friends see you one way; Canadian colleagues see you another. A quality that seems ordinary in Brazil, such as warmth with strangers or the ability to improvise when plans collapse, may seem remarkable in Canada. A habit that felt normal in Canada may be admired at home. Each culture is a mirror that notices different things.

The psychologists William Maddux and Adam Galinsky found, in studies published in 2009, that people who had adapted to living in a foreign culture tended to perform better on creative tasks. Their explanation was that seeing the world through two cultures teaches people that there is more than one right way to do things, including more than one right way to be yourself.

Distorting mirrors

Not every mirror tells the truth.

Some people reflect their own fears onto you: "Don't try that, it's too risky." Some reflect the herd, as we saw in Chapter 3: "People like us don't do that." Some reflect what they need from you: a family that depends on your income may not want you to change direction, however much you might grow. And some, out of kindness, reflect only flattery.

That is why one person's view is never enough. The value of other people as mirrors comes from **many mirrors at once**: close friends and new acquaintances, Brazilians and Canadians, people from work and people from outside it. When the same quality appears in the stories of people who do not know each other, it is probably real.

Networking, reconsidered

Most people think of networking as a way to find a job: collecting contacts, attending events, asking for referrals. That matters, and my book *The Canadian Networking Code* explains how to do it well.

But this chapter suggests a deeper reason to build a network. **Every new connection is both a window and a mirror.** It can show you an opportunity you could not see, and it can show you a part of yourself you could not see. Daniela did not go to the library looking for a career. She went to practise English. She came home with a new picture of who she was.

That is why networking belongs at the centre of a book about discovering yourself. The people who become antifragile, who grow stronger through disruption, are rarely the ones who face it alone. They are the ones surrounded by mirrors.

Lab 6 — Three Mirrors

Time: one week, for three short conversations. **You need:** a notebook, and three people from different parts of your life.

Step 1 — Choose three mirrors. One person who knows you well, such as a friend or family member. One person who knows you from work or study. One person who knows you only a little: a classmate, a neighbour, a volunteer, a new colleague.

Step 2 — Ask for stories, not opinions. Ask each person one or two of the questions from this chapter. If it feels easier, send the questions by message first. Write down their answers as exactly as you can.

Step 3 — Look for the pattern. Compare the three answers with each other, and with your Gift Inventory from Lab 5. What appears more than once? What surprised you?

Step 4 — Notice the distortions. Did any answer sound like the person's own fears, hopes or needs rather than a description of you? Mark it, and keep it separate.

Step 5 — Say thank you, and offer back. Tell each person what you learned. Then offer to be a mirror for them. Most people have never been asked these questions either.

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Daniela still meets Margaret for coffee once a month. They no longer need to practise English. But Daniela says that one sentence from a stranger changed the direction of her life.

In the next chapter, we turn to the newest mirror of all: one that is available at any hour, never tired and never impatient, and that can be remarkably useful, as long as you remember what it is, and what it is not.

Chapter 7 — AI as Mirror and Challenger

What the mirror showed Patrícia

Patrícia had worked for ten years in Brazil: first in a bank, then in a hospital's administration office, then in a school. In Vancouver, she was not sure what to call herself. Her résumé looked like three different careers, and none of them led anywhere obvious.

One evening, after doing the Gift Inventory in this book, she tried something new. She described her working life to an AI assistant in detail: the jobs, the tasks, the moments she was proud of, the problems people brought to her. Then she asked: *"What patterns do you see across these three jobs? What might I be good at that I haven't noticed?"*

The answer surprised her. Across all three jobs, the AI pointed out, people had come to her to resolve conflicts. At the bank, it was angry customers. At the hospital, it was disagreements between departments. At the school, it was parents and teachers. She had always thought of this as something she just *did*, not a skill.

But Patrícia did not stop there, and that is the most important part of her story. She did not accept the machine's pattern as the truth about herself. She tested it. She called two former colleagues in Brazil and asked them for a story about her at her best. Both described her calming a tense situation. Then she volunteered to help settle a dispute at her community centre, to see how the work felt here, in English. It felt right.

Today she is studying workplace mediation, and her three "different careers" have become one clear story.

AI saw a pattern quickly. Other people confirmed it. Real experience proved it. And Patrícia decided what to do with it. That order matters, and this chapter explains why.

What AI can genuinely do

Let us begin fairly. As a tool for questioning yourself, AI has real strengths:

- **It sees across your whole story at once.** Patrícia had never connected the bank, the hospital and the school. AI connected them in seconds.
- **It is patient and private.** You can describe your doubts, your failures and your half-formed hopes without embarrassment, at midnight, in imperfect English, as many times as you need.
- **It can argue with you.** You can ask it to challenge your story about yourself, to suggest alternative explanations, or to imagine possible selves you have never considered.
- **It is available to people without mentors.** Many newcomers have lost the network of people who once helped them see themselves. AI is not a replacement for those people, as Chapter 6 made clear, but for someone who is isolated, it can be a starting point.

Used this way, AI is both a **mirror**, reflecting patterns in what you tell it, and a **challenger**, pushing back on the story you have been telling yourself.

Challenging the hype

But it is equally important to be clear about what AI is not. Much of what is said about AI, by its enthusiasts and by its critics, exaggerates. When it comes to understanding yourself, here are four honest limits.

1. It does not know you. An AI assistant knows only what you tell it, and what millions of other people have written. It has never seen you work, never watched you calm a room or organize a crisis. If your description of yourself is incomplete, and Chapter 5 explained why it usually is, the mirror reflects the incomplete version.

2. It tends to agree with you. In a 2023 study, researchers at Anthropic, the company that makes the Claude assistant, examined several leading AI assistants and found that they consistently showed what the researchers called *sycophancy*: a tendency to agree with users or tell them what they seemed to want to hear, even at the expense of accuracy. The researchers traced part of the cause to the way these systems are trained, using human feedback: people, it turns out, sometimes prefer a convincing, agreeable answer to a correct one. If you describe yourself with pride, the mirror may reflect that pride back, polished and enlarged. **A flattering mirror can be worse than no mirror at all**, because it feels like the truth.

3. It gives the herd's answer. Chapter 3 showed why following the herd feels safe. AI can become a new kind of herd. Language models tend to produce the most likely response: what many people have written about situations like yours. Ask "what career suits a Brazilian accountant in Vancouver?" and you will get a sensible, conventional answer. Researchers Anil Doshi and Oliver Hauser found, in a 2024 study, that people who used AI ideas in creative writing produced work that was rated better but was also more similar to everyone else's. A mirror that shows everyone the same reflection cannot reveal what is unique about you.

4. It can hand you a new label. This is the deepest danger, and it goes to the heart of this book. Ask "based on my experience, who am I and what should I become?" and AI will answer, fluently and confidently: *"You are a natural leader who should become a project manager."* It sounds wise. It may even be partly true. But if you accept it without question, you have simply swapped one label for another. Your profession used to tell you who you were. Now a machine does.

That is why AI is neither the hero nor the villain of this chapter. It is a powerful instrument with real limits, and the person holding it remains responsible for what they conclude.

No clever prompt removes these limits completely. Better questions reduce them; they do not turn AI into an expert on you. Its usefulness also depends on the task. AI can be an excellent brainstorming partner, practice partner or source of other perspectives. It is not a substitute for real experience, for the people who know you, or for qualified professional advice when you need it. The line that matters most is simple: **use AI to think better, never to avoid thinking.**

Using AI as a challenger

The limits above do not mean you should avoid AI for self-reflection. They mean you should use it differently: less as a mirror that tells you who you are, and more as a **challenger** that makes you think harder about the story you already tell.

Here are some ways to ask that work against flattery, the herd and the new label:

- **Ask for weaknesses, not only strengths.** *"What patterns do you see in my story, including at least one weakness or blind spot?"*
- **Ask for evidence.** *"For each strength you mention, show me the exact part of my story that supports it, and anything that goes against it."*
- **Ask it to disagree.** *"I believe I am not creative. Make the strongest possible case that I am wrong, using only what I've told you."*
- **Ask about your feared self.** *"What possible selves might I be avoiding because I'm afraid of failing?"*
- **Ask beyond the herd.** *"What is the usual advice for someone like me? Now give me three unusual directions that fit my particular story."*

- **Ask about its uncertainty.** *"Which of your suggestions are you least confident about, and what would you need to know to be more sure?"*

Notice what these questions have in common. None of them asks AI to decide who you are. Each one uses AI to widen your view, test your assumptions or surface possibilities. The conclusions remain yours to draw.

Three tests

Whatever AI suggests about you, test it three ways before you believe it. These tests bring together everything in Part II.

1. **The evidence test (Chapter 5).** Can you find at least three real moments in your own history where this capability appeared? If not, it may be the mirror's imagination, or your own flattering description reflected back.
2. **The people test (Chapter 6).** Ask two or three people who know you, ideally from different parts of your life, whether they recognize it. If people who do not know each other describe the same quality, it is probably real.
3. **The reality test (the subject of Part III).** Try it in a small, real situation, like Patrícia's community-centre dispute. Does it work? Does it feel right? Would you want to do it again?

Only a capability that passes all three tests deserves a place in your answer to *Who am I?*

Responsibility stays with you

It is tempting to hand difficult questions about ourselves to a machine that answers so confidently. It saves the discomfort of not knowing. But this is exactly where the argument of this book draws its firmest line.

AI can help you question the incomplete understanding you have of yourself. It can surface patterns, challenge assumptions and suggest possibilities you never imagined. **It cannot take responsibility for what you conclude.** That responsibility belongs to the person who will live the life.

This is not a weakness of AI. It is simply the difference between a tool and a person. Your experience, your values, your relationships and your choices are yours. A mirror, however clever, only reflects.

Lab 7 — The Honest Mirror

Time: about one hour, plus the tests. **You need:** an AI assistant, your notes from Labs 5 and 6, and a notebook.

Step 1 — Tell your story. Describe your working life to AI in detail: jobs, tasks, proud moments, the problems people brought to you, and your life outside work. Include what you discovered in Labs 5 and 6.

Step 2 — Ask as a challenger. Use at least four of the questions from this chapter. Ask for weaknesses, evidence, disagreement and uncertainty, not only praise.

Step 3 — Notice the flattery and the herd. Mark any answer that sounds too pleasing, or too much like conventional advice. Ask a follow-up question about each.

Step 4 — Apply the three tests to the two most promising patterns: evidence from your history, confirmation from people, and one small real-world trial.

Step 5 — Decide for yourself. Write down which patterns you accept, which you reject and which you want to test further, and why. The decision is yours, not the machine's.

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The end of Part II

Look at what you have done in these three chapters.

You have looked inside, at the gifts you take for granted and the possible selves you carry (Chapter 5). You have looked through other people's eyes, using many mirrors at once (Chapter 6). And you have learned to use AI as a challenger rather than a judge, testing everything it suggests (this chapter).

Together, these are the tools for questioning an incomplete understanding of yourself. None of them is complete alone. Your own view is too close. Other people's views can be distorted. AI's view is fast but shallow, agreeable and conventional. But used together, and tested against reality, they can show you a self that is larger than any label.

Discovering that self is only half the work. In Part III, we turn to the other half: developing what you have discovered into real capability, through small bets, beginner's courage and learning that you build rather than borrow.

Part III — Developing the Self

Turning discoveries into real capability: the antifragile path.

Chapter 8 — Small Bets

Nathalia's small steps

Nathalia had been an accountant in Curitiba for twelve years. In Vancouver, she found work as a bookkeeper. It paid the rent. It did not excite her.

What excited her was something she had noticed almost by accident. Every time she used a badly designed website or app, she found herself redesigning it in her head: moving the buttons, simplifying the forms, imagining how it could be clearer. A friend told her this was a real profession, called user experience design, or UX.

Many people in Nathalia's position would have done one of two things. Some would have ignored the idea: *I'm an accountant, I have a family, this is not the time.* Others would have jumped: quit the bookkeeping job, spent their savings on an expensive course and hoped for the best.

Nathalia did neither. She took small steps.

First, she spent two weekends learning the basics online, using AI to explain the terms she did not understand. Then she offered to redesign the website of a small Brazilian bakery near her home, for free, to see if she enjoyed real work with a real client. She did. Next, she asked three UX designers in Vancouver for twenty minutes of their time over coffee, and asked them what the job was really like. Two of them said yes.

Only after six months of these small experiments did she enrol in a part-time course. She kept her bookkeeping job until she had her first paid design project. Today she works as a UX designer for a financial services company,

where her accounting background turns out to be a rare and valuable advantage.

At no point did Nathalia bet everything. At every point, she learned something new about herself.

That is a calculated risk.

You have done this before

Many people believe they are "not risk-takers." If you are an immigrant, that is almost certainly not true.

Think about what you did to get here. You probably did not wake up one morning and buy a plane ticket. You researched. You compared cities. You saved money for years. You studied English. You gathered documents, filled in forms and waited. You talked to people who had made the move before you. You probably had a plan B, in case things went wrong.

That was a calculated risk, and a very big one. You took it because the thing you wanted, your something more, was worth it, and because you had prepared well enough to make the risk bearable.

The people who ride the AI wave are not the ones who take the biggest risks. They are the ones who take **calculated** risks: carefully prepared, carefully sized and, wherever possible, reversible.

You already know how to do this. You just need to do it again, on a smaller scale, more often.

How big-wave surfers take risks

From the beach, big-wave surfers look fearless, even a little crazy. They paddle into walls of water taller than a building. One mistake could be fatal.

The big-wave surfer Sergio Faria put it simply: **"The best waves come with more dangers."** The waves worth riding are rarely the safe ones.

But the best of them are among the most careful athletes in the world. Their courage rests on preparation:

- **They train for years.** They build strength, breath control and skill long before they face a giant wave.
- **They study the ocean.** They read forecasts, watch the swells and learn exactly how each break behaves.
- **They choose their moment.** Not every wave is worth riding. They let many pass and commit only to the right one.
- **They plan for failure.** Big-wave surfers work with safety teams on jet skis, ready to pull them out if they fall. Many wear flotation vests designed to bring them back to the surface.

This is what a calculated risk looks like. The surfer does not avoid the wave, and does not throw themselves at it blindly. They prepare, they read the conditions, they choose, and they make sure that falling will not be the end.

You can approach the AI wave in exactly the same way. Prepare by learning. Read the conditions by understanding your field. Choose the right opportunities. And always have a plan for what happens if an experiment fails.

Act your way into a new identity

Most of us believe that change should follow a sensible order. First, you think carefully about who you are. Then you decide what you want. Then you make a plan. Then you act.

Herminia Ibarra, a professor of organizational behaviour at London Business School, studied dozens of professionals who changed careers. She found that for most of them, it did not work that way.

In her book *Working Identity*, she describes how successful career changers rarely started with a clear plan. Instead, they experimented. They tried small projects, took on side work, talked to people in new fields and

spent time in new communities. Through these experiments, they discovered what they were good at and what they enjoyed. Their new identity came from *doing*, not from thinking alone.

Ibarra's conclusion was striking: we often cannot think our way into a new identity. We have to **act our way into it**.

This connects directly to the loop from Chapter 4. Each small experiment reveals something new about you. Nathalia did not know she would love UX design until she redesigned the bakery's website. She did not know her accounting background would be an advantage until she talked to designers in financial companies. Every step taught her something she could not have learned by sitting at home and reflecting.

So do not wait until you are sure who you want to become. You may never be sure. Instead, design small experiments that let you find out.

Antifragile bets

In Chapter 1, we met Nassim Nicholas Taleb's idea of antifragility: things that grow stronger from shocks rather than simply surviving them. Taleb's practical advice for becoming antifragile is surprisingly close to what Nathalia did.

His core idea is to arrange your life so that **the downside of any experiment is small and survivable, while the upside is open.** A small bet that fails costs you an evening, a little embarrassment, perhaps a few hundred dollars. A small bet that succeeds might change the direction of your life. When the losses are limited and the possible gains are large, many small experiments are far safer than one big leap, and far more promising than doing nothing at all.

Taleb also warns against the one kind of risk you must never take: **the risk of ruin.** A bet that could cost you your family's security, your visa or your health is not a calculated risk, however exciting it seems. Nathalia kept

her bookkeeping job until her first paid design project arrived. She never risked ruin. She risked evenings.

There is one more antifragile habit in her story. Each experiment, whether it went well or badly, gave her **information**. The bakery website showed her she loved the work. One of the designers who declined to meet her taught her something too: that cold messages work better with a personal connection. Nothing was wasted. That is the difference between a resilient person, who survives setbacks, and an antifragile one, who learns from them.

New experiments come from new people

Look again at where Nathalia's experiments came from. A friend told her UX was a real profession. A bakery owner she knew agreed to let her try. Three designers, two of them strangers, received her request; two agreed to talk.

Almost every step of her journey came through another person.

Herminia Ibarra found the same pattern in the career changers she studied. Alongside *crafting experiments*, she identified *shifting connections* as one of the main ways people moved into a new identity: spending time with people in the world they were moving toward, who could show them what the work was really like and who saw them as someone who might belong there.

This is why, in Chapter 6, we described every new connection as both a mirror and a window. In this chapter, it is something more: **a source of experiments.** The people you meet create opportunities to test yourself that you could never create alone. If you want more small bets, you need more people.

And this is where AI can help without taking over. It can help you find communities to join, prepare thoughtful questions for a coffee conversation, or write the message you are nervous to send. But the conversation itself, and the door it opens, belongs to people.

AI lowers the price of adventure

Here is where the AI wave becomes a gift.

Not long ago, exploring a new direction was expensive. To find out whether you might enjoy a different career, you often had to quit your job, go back to school or spend money you did not have. The first step was so costly that most people never took it.

AI has changed that. Today, many first steps cost almost nothing but a few evenings:

- **Learn the basics of a field** by asking AI to explain it at your level, then testing your understanding.
- **Build a rough prototype** of an app, a website, a product or a business plan.
- **Research an industry**: who the employers are, what skills they need, what problems they face.
- **Practise a job interview** in a new field, and ask for honest feedback on your answers.
- **Prepare for a coffee conversation** with someone in the field, so you ask better questions.

This is what I mean when I say **AI lowers the price of adventure.** It makes the first steps cheap, so you can afford to take more of them.

But there is a catch, and it is important. An experiment only counts when it meets the real world. You can explore a new field with AI for months and still learn nothing about whether you belong in it, because AI cannot tell you how it *feels* to do the work, or whether real people will value what you offer.

Nathalia used AI to learn the basics. But the experiments that changed her life happened outside the screen: the bakery owner, the two designers who said yes, the first paying client. That is the pattern to follow. **Use AI to make the first steps cheap, so you can afford to take the real ones.**

When there is little room for risk

Not everyone has the same room to experiment, and it would be unfair to pretend otherwise.

You may have a work permit tied to a specific employer. You may have debts, or family in Brazil who depend on the money you send. You may be a single parent with no time left at the end of the day. For you, "just try something new" can sound like advice from someone who has never been in your situation.

There is also a reason risk feels so heavy for almost everyone. The psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky showed that people tend to feel losses more strongly than equivalent gains. Losing something hurts more than gaining the same thing pleases us. This is called **loss aversion**, and it makes any change feel more dangerous than it really is. For someone who has already lost a great deal in moving countries, the feeling can be even stronger.

So here are three principles for people with little room:

1. **Make the risk smaller, not bigger.** One evening a week is an experiment. One conversation is an experiment. You do not need to change your life to test a direction.
2. **Make it reversible.** Choose experiments you can stop at any time without losing your job, your visa or your savings.
3. **Protect the base.** Keep the job that pays the bills while you explore. Nathalia did. Many successful career changers do.

And one more thing: not every reader should take every risk. If your life right now requires all your energy just to keep the family safe, then keeping the family safe is the right choice. Self-authorship includes knowing when to wait. The point is not to take risks for their own sake. It is to make sure that your own judgment, not fear, is what decides.

Lab 8 — The 30-Day Bet

Time: one hour to plan, then 30 days. **You need:** a notebook, an AI assistant and your calendar.

Step 1 — Choose a direction. Pick one direction you are curious about. It might come from your something more (Chapter 4), from the gifts you discovered in Part II, or simply from something that keeps catching your attention. It does not have to be a career change. It can be a new skill, a new role at your current job or a small side project.

Step 2 — Design the bet. Plan an experiment you can complete in 30 days. It must:

- fit into the time you really have;
- cost little or no money;
- be reversible;
- **end with contact with real people:** a conversation, a small project, feedback from someone in the field.

Ask an AI assistant: *"Help me design a 30-day experiment to test whether [direction] suits me, with less than [X] hours a week."* Then adjust its plan to your real life.

Step 3 — Write your safety plan. What will you protect while you experiment? Your job, your savings, time with your children? Write it down.

Step 4 — Decide in advance. Write what result would make you continue, and what result would make you stop. Deciding now protects you from fear, and from stubbornness, later.

Step 5 — Run it, then reflect. After 30 days, answer: *What did I learn about the work? What did I learn about myself?* Either answer is a success. A bet that tells you "this is not for me" has saved you years.

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Nathalia's life changed because of a bakery website, two cups of coffee, one polite refusal and a lot of small evenings. None of those steps was dramatic. Together, they carried her from one identity to another, without ever risking what mattered most.

You can do the same. In the next chapter, we turn to the hardest part of almost every experiment: being a beginner again.

Chapter 9 — Becoming a Beginner Again

Rodrigo in the role-play

Rodrigo ran a team of forty people in São Paulo. He led meetings, negotiated with suppliers and made decisions that affected millions of reais. He was confident, articulate and respected.

In one of our online lessons, I asked him to try a simple role-play. I would play a landlord, and he would call to ask about an apartment.

He struggled. He searched for words. He mixed up his tenses. When the "landlord" asked a question he did not understand, he froze. Even through the camera, I could see his face turn red.

When we stopped, he was quiet for a moment. "Teacher," he said, "in Brazil I negotiate contracts. Here I can't rent an apartment. I feel like an idiot."

The most important part of the story is what happened next. Rodrigo was back for his next lesson the following week. And the week after that. He kept making mistakes, kept feeling embarrassed and kept coming back. A year later, he was leading meetings again, this time in English.

I have seen this many times, and I have come to believe that the hardest part of riding a new wave is not learning the new skill. **It is tolerating being bad at it first.**

This chapter is about that stage: the uncomfortable, humbling, absolutely necessary stage of becoming a beginner again.

Why experts suffer most as beginners

Being a beginner is uncomfortable for everyone. But it is especially painful for people who used to be experts.

Think about why. A child learning to ride a bicycle expects to fall. Nobody, including the child, thinks less of them. But an experienced professional has spent years building an identity around being competent. For them, every mistake is not just a mistake. It feels like evidence that they are losing who they are.

This is the label problem from Chapter 2, appearing in a new form. When "I am competent" becomes part of your identity, being a beginner feels like an attack on yourself. And so experts often avoid the beginner stage altogether. They stay in areas where they already know the answers. They say "that's not my field." They let others learn the new tools.

Language learners feel this with special intensity. In 1986, the researchers Elaine Horwitz, Michael Horwitz and Joann Cope described what they called *foreign language anxiety*: a particular kind of nervousness that adults feel when they must communicate in a language they have not mastered. Speaking a new language exposes you. You cannot hide your mistakes. You may sound less intelligent than you are. For a proud professional, that can be almost unbearable.

And the AI wave will require many of us to feel this way again, perhaps several times, as tools and jobs keep changing. The people who ride it will not be those who avoid feeling like beginners. They will be those who have learned to tolerate it.

What my students teach me

People often think teachers teach and students learn. In my lessons, it often works the other way around.

Every week, I watch successful adults do something most people avoid for their entire lives. Doctors, engineers, lawyers and managers log on, one to one,

and choose to be beginners. They speak slowly, make mistakes out loud, ask questions that sound basic and try again. They do this not once, but week after week, for months and years.

I am not sure they realize how remarkable that is.

Most people facing the AI wave have not been beginners at anything important for a very long time. They have forgotten how it feels, and they are afraid of it. My students have not forgotten. They live it every day. **In my experience, they are some of the best-prepared people for the wave that is coming, though most of them do not know it.**

What do they do that others don't? From what I see, three things:

- **They separate the mistake from the person.** A wrong verb tense is a wrong verb tense, not a judgment on their intelligence.
- **They focus on progress, not perfection.** They compare themselves with who they were three months ago, not with native speakers.
- **They keep showing up.** On the days they feel foolish, they come anyway. Especially on those days.

If you are learning English, you are already practising the most important skill this book can describe. You just may not have noticed.

Don't wait for Canada to teach you English

Some of my students make a decision before they move that seems sensible. They will wait to learn English properly until they arrive. In Canada, they reason, they will be speaking English all day, every day, and they will pick it up naturally.

It rarely works that way. Many newcomers spend their first months, sometimes their first years, speaking very little English. They live with family, shop where a few words are enough, work in jobs where nobody needs them to talk, and spend their evenings with other Brazilians. **You do not speak English all the time in Canada until you land a job where you get to**

speak it. And landing that job usually requires the English you were hoping to learn.

So my advice is simple. If you are still preparing to move, study English as much as possible before you leave. Every hour you invest at home is an hour you will not have to find later, when you are tired, busy and under pressure. If you are already here, do not wait for immersion to happen to you. Create it: lessons, conversation groups, volunteering, and practice with AI, which we look at later in this chapter.

Being a beginner is uncomfortable. Being a beginner in your first Canadian job interview is much more uncomfortable than being one at your kitchen table.

Words that keep a learner moving

One of the simplest ways to survive the beginner stage is to change the words you use about yourself.

Experts tend to use words that close a door: *"I'm not good with technology." "That's not my area." "I'm too old to learn this."* Each one is a small label, and each one ends the conversation before learning can begin.

Learners use words that keep the door open:

- *"I don't know yet."*
- *"I need to look into that."*
- *"My understanding may be incomplete."*
- *"I can learn this."*
- *"Can you explain that again, more slowly?"*

These are not admissions of weakness. They are the language of growth. The word *yet*, in particular, is powerful. "I don't know" is a wall. "I don't know *yet*" is a road.

Try noticing, for one week, how often you use closing words about yourself, especially about technology and AI. Then try replacing just one of

them with an opening one. It sounds small. For many people, it is where the change begins.

Believing is not enough

You may have heard of the idea of a "growth mindset": the belief that abilities can be developed through effort. It became very popular in schools and workplaces, and the idea behind it is appealing.

But it is important to be honest about the evidence. In 2023, the psychologists Brooke Macnamara and Alexander Burgoyne reviewed more than sixty studies of programs designed to teach students a growth mindset. They concluded that the apparent effects on academic achievement were likely due to weaknesses in how the studies were designed and reported. Another team, analyzing the research differently, found meaningful benefits for some groups of students, especially those facing more difficulty. The debate continues.

What does this mean for you? Simply that **believing you can learn is not enough.** A positive attitude can help you start. But what actually builds capability is what happens next: practice, feedback, real use and time.

Rodrigo did not become fluent because he believed in himself. He became fluent because he came back every week, made hundreds of mistakes, received correction and used English in real situations until it became his own.

That is good news, in a way. You do not have to feel confident to learn. You only have to keep practising. Confidence usually arrives later, as a result of progress, not as a condition for it.

Growing through difficulty

There is a body of research on what psychologists Richard Tedeschi and Lawrence Calhoun named *post-traumatic growth*: the positive changes some people report after going through serious hardship. People describe a greater

appreciation of life, closer relationships, a stronger sense of their own capability and new possibilities they had not seen before.

The idea fits this book, and especially the immigrant experience. Many of my students say that the hardest years of their lives also showed them what they were capable of.

But it needs to be handled honestly. Researchers continue to debate how much of this growth is real change and how much is the way people make sense of a painful experience afterwards. And growth after hardship is not automatic. It is not the hardship itself that helps. It is what surrounds it.

Two conditions appear again and again:

- **Recovery.** People grow from difficulty they can survive and recover from. A beginner who is overwhelmed every day, with no rest and no small successes, does not grow. They burn out. Rodrigo could tolerate his embarrassment because each lesson ended, and he rested, and came back a week later.
- **Support.** People rarely grow alone. Rodrigo had a teacher who waited patiently while he searched for words, and encouraged him. Someone, somewhere, believed he would get there. That support is what turns a painful beginner stage into an antifragile one.

So if you are in a hard beginner stage right now, the question is not only "how do I push through?" It is also: "where is my recovery, and who is supporting me?" If the answer to either is "nowhere" or "nobody," that is the first thing to fix.

AI: a patient practice partner

Here is one of the most hopeful things about the AI wave: it makes the beginner stage much less painful.

The hardest part of being a beginner is often social. It is the fear of looking foolish in front of other people. AI removes much of that fear. With an AI assistant you can:

- **Ask the "stupid" question** that you would be embarrassed to ask a colleague.
- **Ask for the same explanation five times**, in five different ways, without anyone losing patience.
- **Practise a conversation** (a job interview, a phone call to a landlord, a difficult meeting) as many times as you need, at midnight if you want.
- **Make mistakes privately**, learn from them and only then perform in public.

For Rodrigo, this would have changed a great deal. He could have practised that landlord call twenty times at home before trying it with me.

But notice the last step: *and only then perform in public.* AI is a practice field, not the match. Real progress still requires real situations, real people and real risk of mistakes. The goal is to use AI to make the beginner stage shorter and less painful, not to avoid it entirely. If you only ever practise with AI, you will never discover whether you can do it without the safety net.

When to persist, and when to stop

One last point. Not every beginner stage leads to mastery, and not every new direction is worth continuing. Sometimes, after real effort, you discover that a skill or a field is not right for you. That is not failure. It is information.

The difference between quitting and choosing is whether you decided with your judgment or with your embarrassment. Give a new skill a fair chance, with real practice, before you judge it. If you then decide to stop, stop with confidence. Persistence, like risk, should be calculated.

Lab 9 — The Beginner's Journal

Time: 10 minutes a session, for two weeks. **You need:** a notebook and an AI assistant.

Step 1 — Choose something you are bad at. Pick one skill you currently find difficult and that would help you in the AI wave. It might be using a particular AI tool, speaking English in meetings, basic data analysis or presenting your ideas. Choose something that makes you feel like a beginner.

Step 2 — Practise with AI first. In each session, use an AI assistant as a patient practice partner. Ask it to explain, to quiz you, to role-play a situation, or to give you feedback on your attempts. Ask it to be honest about your mistakes.

Step 3 — Write three lines. After each session, write:

- *What I tried:*
- *How it felt:*
- *One thing I learned:*

Step 4 — Go public once. Before the two weeks end, use the skill once with a real person: in a meeting, a conversation, a small task at work. Write down what happened.

Step 5 — Look back. At the end, read your journal from the beginning. Notice how the "How it felt" lines changed. That change is your proof that the beginner stage passes.

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Rodrigo's story did not end with his embarrassment in the role-play. It ended a year later, in a meeting room in Vancouver, speaking a language he had once struggled to use to rent an apartment.

The beginner stage is not the opposite of expertise. It is the doorway to the next one. In the next chapter, we look at how to make sure that what you learn, with AI's help, becomes truly yours.

Chapter 10 — Built, Not Borrowed

Tokenmaxxing

In May 2026, the Financial Times reported, in an article also published by Ars Technica, on a strange new word inside Amazon: *tokenmaxxing*. According to the report, some employees, under pressure to show that they were using AI, had started using an internal AI tool to automate tasks that were not essential, simply to increase their usage.

It is worth pausing on what this means. The AI tool worked. It did what it was asked. The problem was not the technology. The problem was what people were being measured on. When a company counts how much its employees use AI, rather than what they achieve with it, people learn to use AI to *look* productive instead of to *become* more capable.

Now consider a different person in the same kind of workplace.

Thiago is a Brazilian software tester at a large technology company in downtown Vancouver. He felt the same pressure as everyone else. His manager wanted the team to use AI tools, and quickly. Thiago could have done the minimum: let the tool write his test reports, paste the results and move on.

Instead, he made a decision. Every time the AI did something he could not do himself, he stopped and asked it to explain. How did it write that test? Why that approach? What would happen if the code changed? He spent an extra hour or two each week understanding what the tool was doing. Within a year, he had learned enough about automation and code to move into a better role as a test automation engineer.

Thiago and the tokenmaxxers used the same kind of tool, under the same kind of pressure. One group was performing. Thiago was **building**.

This chapter is about the difference.

Two kinds of capability

When you use AI, you can gain two very different kinds of capability.

Borrowed capability is what you can do *with* the tool. With AI, you can write a report in perfect English, analyze a spreadsheet, draft a legal letter or write code. That capability is real, and it is useful. But it belongs to the tool. When the tool is not there, or when the situation is new and the tool cannot help, the capability disappears.

Built capability is what the tool helped you *become*. It is the knowledge, skill and judgment that stay in your head after the screen is closed. It goes with you to the next job, the next country, the next wave. It becomes part of who you are.

Both kinds have their place. Nobody can build everything. We borrow capability all the time, and we should. But the distinction matters enormously, because the two kinds behave very differently when the wave hits.

Here is the question this chapter will teach you to ask, again and again:

Is this something I should borrow, or something I need to build?

The translation app

If you are learning English, you already understand this distinction better than most people. You have lived it.

Imagine two newcomers in their first month in Vancouver. Both have important meetings with their bank.

The first opens a translation app on her phone. She types in Portuguese; the app speaks in English. The meeting goes well. She gets everything done.

The second struggles through the meeting in his own imperfect English. He is slower. He asks the bank officer to repeat things. He makes mistakes. But he gets through it.

In that moment, the first newcomer clearly did better. She borrowed a capability, and it worked.

But look at them a year later. The first newcomer can still get through meetings, as long as her phone is with her and the conversation is simple enough for the app. She has not become any more bilingual. She still feels like a visitor.

The second newcomer has improved with every difficult conversation. He now speaks with confidence, understands jokes, makes small talk and builds relationships. He has not just completed tasks in English. He has **become** someone who lives in English. And with that came something no app can provide: the feeling of belonging.

Translation apps are wonderful tools. Everyone should use them when they need them. But the app gets you through the meeting. It does not make you bilingual, and it does not make you belong. Only built capability does that.

AI is, in many ways, a translation app for everything. It can get you through almost any task. The question is whether you are also becoming someone new.

Why the struggle builds us

Why did the second newcomer improve while the first did not? Because the struggle itself was doing the work.

The psychologists Robert and Elizabeth Bjork have spent decades studying how people learn. One of their key findings is a concept they call **desirable difficulties**. Some kinds of effort, such as trying to recall

something from memory, practising in varied conditions or working through a problem before seeing the answer, make learning feel slower and harder in the moment. But they produce much stronger and longer-lasting learning. The effort that feels like failure is often exactly what builds the skill.

AI is extraordinarily good at removing difficulty. That is its gift. But it means that, if we are not careful, AI can remove precisely the struggle we needed.

Psychologists call it *cognitive offloading* when we use tools to reduce the mental effort a task requires: writing a shopping list instead of remembering it, using a calculator instead of doing arithmetic in our heads. Offloading is often smart. It frees our minds for more important things. But when we offload a skill we actually need to develop, we lose the chance to develop it.

The research on AI and learning, which we look at more closely below, shows both sides of this. **AI that makes you think can accelerate learning dramatically. AI that thinks for you can replace it.**

The same tool can do either. The difference is how you use it.

The learning accelerator

The good news is that, used to build rather than to borrow, AI may be the most powerful learning tool people have ever had.

Consider Camila. A friend had passed her name to a recruiter at a logistics company in Burnaby, for a supply-chain planning role close to her experience in Brazil, but with new software, new vocabulary and a Canadian style of interview she had never practised. She had six weeks.

Every evening, after her children were asleep, she spent an hour with an AI assistant. She asked it to explain the software in simple English, then to quiz her on it. She practised the vocabulary aloud. She asked it to play a Canadian interviewer, first friendly and then difficult, and to tell her honestly where her answers were weak. Six weeks later, she walked into the interview

alone, with no phone and no AI, and answered in her own words. She got the job.

The research supports stories like Camila's, with an important condition. In 2025, a team at Harvard published a randomized controlled trial in *Scientific Reports*: physics students who learned with a carefully designed AI tutor learned significantly more, in less time, than students in an active-learning class. But the tutor did not hand out answers. It guided students step by step and made them reason for themselves. In another experiment, published as a working paper in December 2025, economists Mira Fischer, Holger Rau and Rainer Michael Rilke found that university students with access to an AI tutor scored meaningfully higher on an exam, and that, in early results, it seemed to help most those with stronger self-regulation skills.

The lesson is the same as this chapter's: **AI accelerates whatever you bring to it.** Bring discipline, purpose and the willingness to think, and it can help you build capability faster than ever.

Six roles for building

Camila used AI in several different roles. Each is useful for building rather than borrowing:

Role	What it does for you	Try asking
Tutor	Teaches step by step	*"Teach me the basics of X. Check my understanding after each step."*
Explainer	Explains at your level	*"Explain this again, more simply, with an everyday example."*
Practice partner	Lets you practise as often as you need	*"Ask me ten questions about X, one at a time, and correct my answers."*
Simulator		

Role	What it does for you	Try asking
	Recreates real situations safely	*"Play a Canadian interviewer for a planning role. Be tough."*
Critic	Finds the weaknesses in your work	*"What are the three weakest parts of this answer?"*
Planner	Turns a goal into a learning plan	*"I have six weeks and an hour a day. Make me a plan to learn X."*

Four habits make the difference between building and borrowing:

- **Ask it to question you, not just answer you.** In a well-known 2006 study, Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke found that students who practised recalling information remembered much more a week later than students who simply re-read it.
- **Try first, then compare.** Write your own answer before asking for AI's. The effort is a desirable difficulty.
- **Come back to it.** Ask AI to quiz you again on last week's material.
- **Check what matters.** AI can be confidently wrong. Confirm important facts with a trusted source or a real expert.

In a wave as fast as this one, nobody can learn everything. What matters is the ability to learn quickly, again and again. That is built capability of the most valuable kind.

When to borrow, when to build

None of this means you should avoid AI or do everything the hard way. Human beings have always borrowed capability from tools. Writing let us borrow memory. Calculators let us borrow arithmetic. Maps let us borrow knowledge of places we have never been. That is how civilization advances: we

hand routine work to tools so that our minds can do something more valuable.

Borrowing is not the problem. Borrowing what you needed to build is the problem.

So how do you decide? Here are four questions:

1. **Is this skill part of my value?** If it is central to what you bring, to your work or your future direction, build it. If it is peripheral, borrowing is fine.
2. **Will I need it when the tool is not there?** In a job interview, a crisis, a conversation, a new situation the tool was not designed for? If yes, build it.
3. **Do I need to judge the result?** You cannot check AI's work in an area you do not understand. If you must decide whether the answer is right, you need at least enough built capability to evaluate it.
4. **Does this skill connect to my something more?** If it moves you toward the destination you named in Chapter 4, invest in building it.

If the answer to all four is no, borrow freely and save your energy for what matters. If any answer is yes, use AI as a teacher, not as a substitute: ask it to explain, to quiz you, to let you try first, and to show you what you got wrong.

What leaves with you

There is one more reason built capability matters, and for immigrants it may be the most important.

In Chapter 1, we saw that there is no safe harbour anymore. No job, employer or title can promise to stay the same. If your job changes, or disappears, what goes with you?

Not the tools your employer paid for. Not the AI subscriptions, the software, or the systems. Not the capability you borrowed. All of that stays behind.

What leaves with you is what you built. The skills in your head, the judgment you developed, the understanding you earned through effort. That is the only kind of capability no company announcement can take away. It is the safety that moves from the place to the person.

Remember the survey from Chapter 3: people with more confidence in their own abilities tended to think more critically about AI's answers. Built capability does not just stay with you. It also helps you use AI better, because you can tell when it is wrong.

The tokenmaxxers were measured on borrowed capability. Thiago invested in built capability. If both lose their jobs tomorrow, only Thiago walks out the door richer than he walked in.

Lab 10 — The Borrow-or-Build Audit

Time: about 45 minutes. **You need:** a notebook and your memory of the last month.

Step 1 — List your AI uses. Write down ten ways you used AI, or could have used it, in the last month. Be specific: *"wrote an email to a client," "summarized a report," "translated a document," "explained a technical term."* If you have not used AI yet, list ten tasks you would like it to help with.

Step 2 — Ask the key question. For each one, answer: *"Could I do this without AI now?"* and *"Do I need to be able to?"*

Step 3 — Sort them. Put each use into one of two columns:

- **Borrow:** fine to keep using AI; you do not need to master this.
- **Build:** you should be developing this capability yourself.

Use the four questions from this chapter to decide.

Step 4 — Move one across. Choose one task from the Build column. For the next month, whenever you use AI for it, change how you use it: ask it to explain its reasoning, try the task yourself first and then compare, or ask it to quiz you on what you have learned.

Step 5 — Test yourself. At the end of the month, do that task once without AI. Notice what you can now do on your own. That is capability you have built, and it is yours to keep.

Step 6 — Learn it, then prove it. Choose one skill your next step needs. Spend two weeks learning it with AI, using at least three of the six roles, and trying first before comparing. Then demonstrate it with no AI at all: explain it to a friend, use it in a real task or teach it to someone. What you can do without the tool is what you have built.

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AI may be the most powerful tool for both borrowing and building ever invented. The same tool, used two ways, can make you dependent or make you grow.

In the next chapter, we turn to one of the most surprising things people can build with AI's help, especially people who believe they cannot: creative work in their own voice.

Chapter 11 — Creating Beyond the Label

"I'm not creative"

Beatriz said it often, and with complete certainty. "I'm an accountant," she would laugh. "I'm not creative. I'm the opposite of creative."

In Vancouver, she noticed something about the Brazilian families she knew. Many of them were confused by Canadian money matters: tax returns, credit scores, the difference between RRSPs and TFSAs, the benefits for children they did not know they could claim. They made expensive mistakes because nobody had explained the system to them in a way they could understand.

Beatriz understood it. She had spent two years learning it for her own family. One evening, almost as a joke, she asked an AI assistant: *"How would I create a short workshop to explain Canadian personal finance to Brazilian newcomers?"*

The AI gave her a structure. She disliked half of it, which was useful in itself, because it showed her what she *did* want. She asked for ideas to make the subject less boring. She rejected most of those too, but one sparked her own idea: telling the story of her family's first Canadian tax return, mistakes and all. She asked AI to help her turn her notes into clear slides, then rewrote every slide in her own words, mixing Portuguese and English the way her community actually speaks.

The first workshop, in a church hall, had twelve people. The third had sixty.

Beatriz still says she is not creative. But she designed something original, for a real audience, that no one else had made. If that is not creativity, what is?

Creativity is not a profession

"I'm not creative" is one of the most common labels people carry. It usually means: *I am not an artist, a musician or a writer.*

But creativity is not a profession. It is the ability to make something new and useful: to see a problem differently, connect ideas that were not connected before, or find a better way to do something. By that definition, creativity is everywhere:

- The engineer who finds an elegant solution to a design problem.
- The nurse who invents a better way to organize a busy shift.
- The teacher who explains a difficult idea with the perfect example.
- The parent who turns a boring chore into a game.
- The immigrant who builds a life from nothing in a country whose rules they had to learn from scratch.

If you have done any of these things, you are creative. The label told you otherwise because creativity, like so many capabilities, hides in familiar places.

AI as a creative collaborator

For many people, the hardest part of creating something is the beginning: the blank page, the empty screen, the feeling of not knowing where to start. AI is extraordinarily good at removing that obstacle.

It can give you ten ideas in ten seconds. You may dislike nine of them, but the act of disliking them tells you what you actually want. It can propose structures, suggest combinations and help you turn rough notes into

something organized. For people who believe they are "not creative," this can be transformative.

The research supports this. In a 2024 experiment published in *Science Advances*, Anil Doshi and Oliver Hauser asked people to write short stories, some with access to story ideas from AI. Readers, who did not know which stories had AI help, rated the AI-assisted stories as more creative, better written and more enjoyable. And the benefit was greatest for the writers who were least creative to begin with.

In other words, AI helped most exactly the people who believed they could not create.

Keeping your own voice

But the same study found something else. The AI-assisted stories were more similar to one another than the stories people wrote alone. Each writer improved, but together they became more alike. The researchers described it as a kind of social dilemma: each individual has a good reason to use AI, but if everyone does, we may all lose some variety.

This is the herd again, from Chapters 3 and 7, appearing in creative form. AI's ideas tend to come from the most common patterns in human writing. If you simply accept them, your work will sound like everyone else's.

The answer is not to avoid AI. It is to **bring what only you have.** AI can supply structure, options and polish. It cannot supply:

- **Your experience.** Beatriz's story of her family's first Canadian tax return was the heart of her workshop. No machine could have invented it.
- **Your community.** She knew how Brazilian families in Vancouver talk, what they worry about and what makes them laugh.
- **Your taste.** She rejected most of AI's suggestions. Knowing what to reject is a creative act.

- **Your voice.** She rewrote every slide in her own words.

A useful rule: **AI collaborates; you remain the author.** Use its ideas as raw material, not as the finished product. The more of yourself you put in, the more original the result.

For readers who live between two cultures, there is a particular source of originality here. In Chapter 6, we saw that living between Brazil and Canada gives you double vision: you notice what each culture takes for granted. Beatriz's workshop existed because she lived in that space between. That double vision is raw material no AI can supply.

One caution: not everyone needs to be an artist, and not every idea needs to be original. The goal of this chapter is not to pressure you to perform creativity. It is to free you from a label that may have kept you from trying.

Lab 11 — Create Outside Your Label

Time: two to three hours, spread over a week. **You need:** an AI assistant and a notebook.

Step 1 — Find a small need. Look around your community, workplace or family. What is something useful that does not yet exist? A guide, a workshop, a simple tool, a story, a better way of organizing something.

Step 2 — Ask for raw material. Ask AI for ten ideas or a rough structure. Then write down which ideas you dislike, and why. That is your taste speaking.

Step 3 — Add what only you have. Write down one personal experience, one thing you know about your community and one idea from your Brazilian or Canadian life that could make this project unique. Build them in.

Step 4 — Make it, in your voice. Create a first version. Let AI help with organization and polish, but rewrite the final words yourself.

Step 5 — Keep score. Note which ideas were yours and which were AI's. Then share the result with at least one real person.

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Beatriz still calls herself an accountant. That is fine. But she is also the person who helped sixty people understand their new country's money. The label never mentioned that. She had to create it.

This completes Part III. You have seen how discoveries become capability: through small bets, the courage to be a beginner, learning you build rather than borrow, and creation in your own voice. In Part IV, we turn to what must stay with you through all of it: your judgment, a worth larger than any job, and the people who ride with you.

Part IV — Remaining Responsible

Keeping our judgment, our worth and our people while the wave keeps coming.

Chapter 12 — Two Minds at the Table

Fernanda's decision

Fernanda manages a small customer-service team at a Vancouver company. Last winter, she faced one of the hardest decisions of her career. Two members of her team were in open conflict. Their work was suffering, and so was everyone else's. Her director told her to fix it within a month.

She could have opened an AI assistant and typed: *"Two employees are in conflict. What should I do?"* She would have received a clear, sensible, well-organized answer. She might even have followed it.

Instead, she did something different. She described the situation in detail, leaving out names and anything confidential and following her company's rules on which AI tools staff may use, and asked the AI to help her *think*. She asked it to list all her options, including ones she had not considered. She asked what assumptions she might be making about each person. She asked how each of them might see the situation from their side. She asked it to argue against her first instinct, which was to move one of them to another team. And she asked what could go wrong with each choice.

The conversation took an hour. Several of the AI's suggestions did not fit her team at all; she knew the people, and the machine did not. But two of its questions changed her thinking completely. She realized she had been seeing the conflict as a personality clash, when it was really a disagreement about unclear responsibilities.

She fixed the responsibilities. The conflict faded.

The decision was better than either Fernanda or the AI would have made alone. And it was completely hers.

Two ways to use the same tool

The difference between Fernanda's approach and the first one is the difference between two sentences:

- **"Give me the answer."** AI as a substitute for thinking.
- **"Help me think."** AI as a partner in thinking.

The first is faster. The second is better. It produces better decisions, and it makes you a better thinker over time instead of a more dependent one.

Think of it as two minds sitting at the same table. Each brings something the other does not have:

What AI brings to the table	What you bring to the table
Speed: it can think through many options in seconds	Lived experience: what has actually worked for you
Breadth: knowledge drawn from a vast range of sources	Knowledge of the real people and context involved
The consensus view: what most people would say	Your values: what matters to you and why
Patience: it never gets tired of your questions	Responsibility: you will live with the consequences
No ego: it does not mind being challenged	Judgment: the final decision

Neither column is complete without the other. AI without your experience gives generic answers. Your experience without AI's breadth can miss important options. **Together, they make something better than either alone.**

The habits of a good thinking partner

Fernanda's questions were not magic. They are habits anyone can learn. When you sit down with AI to think through something important, try asking:

- *"What are all my options, including ones I haven't mentioned?"*
- *"What assumptions am I making?"*
- *"How would each person involved see this?"*
- *"What is the strongest argument against what I'm planning to do?"*
- *"What evidence is missing?"*
- *"What could go wrong, and how would I know early?"*

Notice that none of these questions asks AI to decide. Each one asks it to widen your view. The deciding comes later, and it is yours.

When to trust, when to check, when to set aside

A good partnership needs the right level of trust. Too little, and you waste a powerful tool. Too much, and you stop thinking.

Researchers who study people working with automated systems have long described a pattern called **automation bias**: the tendency to accept a machine's answer without checking it, especially when we are busy, tired or unsure. In a widely cited review published in 2010, Raja Parasuraman and Dietrich Manzey showed that this happens even to trained professionals, such as pilots and medical staff, when automated aids are usually reliable.

The 2025 study from Microsoft Research and Carnegie Mellon University that we met in earlier chapters points in the same direction. Knowledge workers with more confidence in AI reported thinking less critically about its answers. Those with more confidence in their own abilities reported thinking more critically.

So here is a simple guide:

- **Trust** AI for generating options, explaining ideas, drafting and finding questions you had not thought to ask.
- **Check** AI on facts, numbers, laws, technical details and anything you will act on or share with others.
- **Set AI aside** for decisions that depend on knowing specific people, on your values or on responsibility you must carry yourself.

Why the final call stays with you

Some people see keeping the final decision as a limitation: a sign that AI is not good enough yet. That misunderstands the partnership.

The final call stays with you because **you are the one who will live with it.** You know Fernanda's team, or your family, or your career, in ways no machine can. You carry the values that make one answer right for you and another wrong. And you are responsible, to your employer, your colleagues and your children, for what happens next.

That is not a weakness of the partnership. It is what makes it a partnership instead of a replacement.

Bring your street smarts, and trust yourself

There is one more thing you bring to the table, and AI does not have it at all: street smarts.

AI has read more than any person ever could. But it has never negotiated with a difficult landlord, found its way through a confusing government office, read the mood of a meeting in a second language or rebuilt a life in a new country. You have. Many of my students built their careers in places where things did not always go according to plan. They learned to read people, to solve problems with whatever was available and to find another

way when the official path was blocked. That practical intelligence does not appear on a résumé, and no AI can supply it.

So bring it. When AI gives you a neat, sensible answer, ask yourself whether it would survive real life. Your street smarts are often the best test.

And then, **trust yourself.** You have made hard decisions before, with less information and more at stake. You crossed a continent. AI can widen your view and sharpen your thinking, but you do not need its permission to decide. When you have listened to the evidence, to the people who know you and to the machine, trust your own judgment.

Lab 12 — Two Minds on One Decision

Time: about one hour. **You need:** an AI assistant, a notebook and one real decision you are facing.

Step 1 — Choose a real decision. It can be about work, career, study or family. Choose something that matters, but not something urgent.

Step 2 — Write your first instinct before asking AI anything. What would you do, and why?

Step 3 — Think together. Describe the situation to AI in detail, then ask at least four of the six questions from this chapter. Do not ask it what you should do.

Step 4 — Sort what you received. Mark each idea: *useful*, *not relevant to my situation*, or *needs checking*. Check anything factual.

Step 5 — Decide, and write your reasons. Make your decision. Then write two or three reasons that are yours alone: things you know about your situation, your people or your values that the AI could not have known.

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Fernanda made a better decision because she brought two minds to the table and kept the final chair for herself. That is the model for using AI throughout your life: not obedience, and not rejection, but partnership.

Responsibility for our thinking is one part of remaining responsible. In the next chapter, we turn to another: building a sense of worth that does not depend on any single job.

Chapter 13 — A Life Larger Than a Job

Two Eduardos

From Monday to Friday, Eduardo works in a warehouse office in Richmond, entering data into a system. In Brazil, he was a civil engineer who managed construction projects. Here, in his first years, the job he could find uses almost none of what he knows. At work, he often feels invisible.

But there is another Eduardo, and you can find him on Saturday mornings.

That Eduardo coaches a youth soccer team of Brazilian and Canadian children, who adore him. On Saturday evenings he cooks *feijoada* for twenty people from the community, and nobody leaves hungry. On Sunday afternoons, he sits with newcomers who have just arrived and helps them rewrite their résumés, because he remembers how lost he felt. People in the community know his name. Children run to greet him. Newcomers call him when they need help.

One day, a friend asked him how he was doing. Eduardo began to describe his job, then stopped. "Actually," he said, "my job is the smallest part of my life right now. And I think I'm happier than I was in Brazil."

That answer contains the central idea of this chapter: **no single job should carry the whole meaning of a life.**

What work gives us, and what it shouldn't have to

In Chapter 2, we met the social psychologist Marie Jahoda, who found that work gives people much more than income. It shapes our days, connects us to others, gives us shared goals, tells us we have a place in society and keeps us active.

Those are real needs. When a job provides all of them, it is a gift. When a job is lost, or shrinks, or changes beyond recognition, losing all of those things at once is genuinely painful.

But here is the danger. If *all* of your structure, belonging, status and purpose come from one job, then that job is carrying an enormous weight. And in a world with no safe harbour, where AI can change any role quickly, asking one job to carry everything is risky.

There is research that helps explain this. In 1987, the psychologist Patricia Linville published a study on what she called **self-complexity**: how many distinct roles and aspects make up a person's sense of who they are. She found that people with more distinct aspects of themselves, such as parent, friend, athlete, volunteer, professional and learner, were less affected by stressful events. When one part of life went badly, the others helped hold them up. Later research has debated how strong this effect is, but the basic idea makes intuitive sense: a self built on many pillars is harder to knock down.

Eduardo's job became a small pillar. But it was not his only one. The coach, the cook, the community helper and the father were holding him up.

This is antifragility in everyday form. A person whose whole self rests on one job is fragile: when the job breaks, they break. A person with many pillars can absorb the shock to one of them, and often use it to strengthen the others. Eduardo lost his engineering title, and the loss pushed him toward a soccer field, a kitchen and a community that made his life larger, not smaller.

Worth is not the same as productivity

Modern economies measure people largely by what they produce: their salary, their output, their job title. It is easy to absorb that measurement and apply it to ourselves. *If I am earning less, I am worth less. If my job is smaller, I am smaller.*

But human worth cannot be reduced to economic productivity. A father who raises kind children is not worth less because his job title is modest. A woman who cares for her aging mother is not worth less because the care is unpaid. A newcomer who helps the next family find their way is contributing something real, even if no employer pays for it.

This matters more as AI changes the world of work. If AI changes how much paid work some people do, or what that work looks like, then the old equation of *job = worth* will hurt more and more people. Societies will need to think hard about how people earn a living in that world. But individuals can start now, by building a sense of worth that does not depend entirely on a paycheque.

The other pillars

Where else can identity and meaning come from? For each person, the answer is different, but here are the pillars I see most often among my students:

- **Family:** being a parent, partner, son or daughter, even across an ocean.
- **Friendship:** the people who know you, not your title.
- **Community:** your church, your neighbourhood, the Brazilian community, your children's school.
- **Faith or philosophy:** whatever gives your life a deeper frame.
- **Learning:** the identity of someone who keeps growing.
- **Creativity:** making things, as we saw in Chapter 11.

- **Health and body:** sport, movement, the outdoors that Vancouver offers so generously.
- **Contribution:** helping others, formally or informally.

And remember the parents from Chapter 2 who gladly let go of a title because their children were safe and thriving. They understood this chapter before they read it. They knew which pillar mattered most to them.

A caution: this is about balance, not indifference

This chapter must not be misread. It does not say that work does not matter, or that you should accept any job and find meaning elsewhere.

For newcomer families, income is essential. Meaningful, well-paid work matters deeply, and the underemployment many immigrants face is a real injustice, not something to be cheerfully accepted. Keep fighting for work that uses what you bring. The rest of this book is designed to help you do exactly that.

The point is balance. Build your career *and* build the other pillars. Then, when a wave hits your job, as waves will, the whole house does not fall. And something interesting happens: a person standing on many pillars can take bigger career risks, because no single risk threatens everything. The loop from Chapter 4 begins to turn in the right direction.

What I saw in my lessons

One of my pillars is teaching, and it has shown me a great deal about this wave.

When AI first arrived in my lessons, I noticed it in the homework: writing that was suddenly perfect, with no trace of the student who wrote it. When I asked some of those students to explain a sentence they had "written," they could not.

But other students were using AI completely differently. They asked it to explain grammar they had not understood, practised conversations with it late at night, and asked it to correct their writing *and explain why*. Those students improved faster than almost anyone I had taught. Same tool. Completely different results.

That taught me that the question was never whether people would use AI. It was **how**. And that question, I realized, belongs in every home as much as every classroom.

The family classroom

The most important classroom in this book is the family kitchen table.

In immigrant families, something remarkable happens after arrival. **Children adapt quickly.** Within months they speak English with a local accent, understand the jokes and feel at home. Many adopt new technology, including AI, faster than anyone else in the house. Their parents, meanwhile, are learning the language as adults, rebuilding careers and missing their own parents back in Brazil.

So the roles begin to reverse. Researchers call it **language brokering** when children translate for their parents at the doctor, the bank or the school meeting. It can be a source of pride for children. But for parents, it can quietly shake the identity of being the one who knows. It is the label crisis of Chapter 2, arriving inside the home.

I have come to see this reversal as an opportunity:

- **Let your children teach you.** If your daughter is better with AI tools than you are, ask her to show you. Being a beginner in front of your own child is humbling, and one of the most powerful lessons you can give her: that learning never stops.
- **Teach them what speed cannot.** Children may learn faster, but parents bring judgment, values, persistence, the ability to tell a good answer from a fluent one, and the meaning of where the family came

from. A child who uses AI brilliantly still needs a parent who asks, *"How do you know that's true?"*

- **Learn visibly.** In an unpredictable world, the most valuable thing you can model is not certainty. It is the courage to keep learning.

No parent can predict what work their children will do in twenty years. But a parent who teaches them to be learners, and to see themselves as more than any label, gives them something that works whatever the future holds. That may be the deepest way to keep the promise most immigrants made when they came: a safe place to raise their children and a land of opportunities.

Every reader is a teacher

You may not stand in front of a classroom, but you teach every day: your children, your colleagues, the newcomer who arrived after you, and yourself. Teachers and schools face real limits, and changing education is easier to describe than to do. But anyone can start with one small change: asking not only *"What did you produce?"* but *"What did you learn, and can you do it yourself?"*

Lab 13 — Your Sources of Worth

Time: about 30 minutes. **You need:** a sheet of paper and coloured pens if you have them.

Step 1 — Draw your pillars. Draw a simple house resting on pillars. Label each pillar with one source of your identity and meaning today: job, family, community, faith, learning, and so on.

Step 2 — Weigh them. Make each pillar thicker or thinner depending on how much of your sense of worth rests on it right now.

Step 3 — Test the house. Imagine your job changed dramatically tomorrow. How much of the house would still stand?

Step 4 — Strengthen one pillar. Choose one pillar you have neglected. Write one small step to strengthen it this month: a call to a friend, a community activity, an hour of learning, a weekend outdoors with your children.

Step 5 — Optional: ask AI. Describe your pillars to an AI assistant and ask: *"What small, realistic ways could I strengthen this neglected area, given my time and budget?"* Choose one idea and try it.

Step 6 — Teach it back, and reverse the roles. Teach someone, perhaps your child, one skill you learned recently, and ask them to explain it back in their own words. Then ask them to teach *you* something they know better than you. Be a beginner, and let them see it.

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Eduardo is still looking for engineering work, and he will probably find it. But whatever happens with his job, he will not lose himself again. He has built a life larger than any title.

In the final chapter, we turn to the one thing no surfer, and no family, can do without: the people who ride with us.

Chapter 14 — Nobody Rides Alone

The safety team

When you watch a big-wave surfer on film, you see one person on one board, alone against a mountain of water.

But the camera is not showing you everything. Just out of frame are the jet skis, driven by people whose job is to pull the surfer out if they fall. On the cliffs, there are spotters watching every wave, ready to call for help. On the beach, there are medics. Before the surfer ever paddles out, there were coaches, training partners and friends who know that particular stretch of ocean.

The most courageous surfers in the world do not ride alone. **Nobody does.**

This book has mostly spoken to you as an individual: your identity, your goals, your learning, your judgment. That was deliberate. But it would be dishonest to end there, because no one rides the wave of AI, or the wave of migration, by themselves.

Networks: the engine of antifragility

Look back over this book and you will notice something. In almost every story of growth, there was another person at the turning point.

Renata's sister and an old friend named the gift she called "nothing special" (Chapter 5). A stranger at a library saw that Daniela was a natural trainer, and then introduced her to the person who hired her (Chapter 6).

Patrícia tested what AI suggested by asking former colleagues (Chapter 7). Nathalia's new direction came through a friend, a bakery owner and three designers (Chapter 8). Rodrigo kept coming back to his lessons because someone waited patiently while he struggled (Chapter 9).

This is not a coincidence. **Other people are how disruption becomes growth.** They help us at every stage of this book's argument:

- **When we defend,** they are often what is missing. Isolated people hold on to the old label hardest, because nobody shows them another version of themselves.
- **When we question,** they are mirrors. They see capabilities we cannot see from the inside.
- **When we develop,** they are windows. They create the experiments, the introductions and the opportunities we could not create alone.
- **When we take risks,** they are the safety team that makes falling survivable.

That is why this book calls networks the engine of antifragility. A person surrounded by mirrors, windows and a safety team can grow from a disruption that would break someone alone. And it is why networking is not a job-search trick. It is how a person becomes larger than their label.

Gustavo's breakthrough

Gustavo spent eight months applying for jobs in Vancouver. He sent more than a hundred applications through online job boards. He received a handful of automated rejections and mostly silence.

His breakthrough came from somewhere he did not expect. At a Brazilian community barbecue, he started talking to the husband of his wife's friend: a man he barely knew. That man worked at an engineering consultancy. He mentioned that his team was struggling to find someone with Gustavo's kind

of experience. A week later, Gustavo had an interview. A month later, he had the job.

It is the pattern Mark Granovetter described, which we met in Chapter 6: people often learn about the jobs they eventually get not through close friends, but through acquaintances, people they know only a little. Close friends tend to know the same people and hear about the same opportunities. Acquaintances connect you to different worlds.

For newcomers, this is both a challenge and a hope. You arrive with few connections. But every conversation, every community event, every class and every coffee can become a weak tie that opens a door. Building those connections deliberately is one of the most important skills a newcomer can learn. It is the subject of my book *The Canadian Networking Code*, for readers who want a full method.

The missing safety team

There is a harder truth that many immigrant families live with, and it deserves to be named.

In Brazil, most people had a safety team they never thought about: their parents, grandparents, aunts, cousins and lifelong friends. Grandparents helped with the children. Family gave advice, lent money in emergencies and simply showed up. That network made risks possible, because if you fell, someone caught you.

When you emigrate, you leave much of that team behind. Your own parents are now a video call away. You worry about their health and cannot be there when they need you. Your children grow up without their grandparents nearby. And when you take a risk in your new country, there may be no one to catch you if it goes wrong. For many families, the hardest moments are not the job rejections. They are the nights when a child is sick and there is no grandmother to call.

This loss is real, and it is one reason the first years can feel so lonely and so frightening. It also explains why some newcomers become so cautious. Without a safety team, every fall feels dangerous.

The answer is not to pretend the loss does not exist. It is to build a new team, slowly and deliberately, while honouring the one you left behind.

Building a new team

A new safety team does not appear overnight. But it can be built, one person at a time. Think of it in layers:

- **The close crew:** your partner, a few close friends, the people you can call at midnight.
- **The community:** other Brazilian families, your church, your neighbourhood, your children's school, the people from your English class.
- **Mentors and guides:** people a few steps ahead of you in your field, who can tell you what they wish they had known.
- **Weak ties:** the acquaintances, colleagues and friends-of-friends who connect you to new opportunities.
- **Connection across distance:** your family in Brazil, still part of your team even from far away.

AI can help with parts of this, too: preparing for a networking conversation, finding community groups, learning about a mentor's field before you meet, writing a message you are nervous to send, or simply making it easier to stay close to family across an ocean. But AI is a tool for building connections, not a replacement for them. The people on your safety team must be people.

The unequal wave

This book has asked a great deal of you: to see beyond your label, to take calculated risks, to keep learning, to think for yourself. All of that matters. But it would be unfair to suggest that individual effort is the whole story.

The wave does not hit everyone equally. Some newcomers arrive with savings and some with debts. Some have permanent residency and some have work permits tied to a single employer. Some have a partner to share the load and some are raising children alone. Some have time to learn new skills and some are working two jobs to pay the rent. Some have credentials Canada recognizes quickly, and some, like Marcéu, face years of exams and paperwork.

If you are struggling, it is not necessarily because you lack courage or effort. Sometimes the conditions are simply harder.

That is why riding this wave well is not only an individual task. It is a shared one:

- **Employers** can introduce AI in ways that build their people rather than only measuring them, offering real training and rewarding what employees achieve, not just how often they use a tool.
- **Schools and colleges** can teach people to learn with AI, not only to produce with it.
- **Governments** can invest in retraining, faster credential recognition and support for people whose work is changing. The International Labour Organization has argued that whether generative AI drives development or exclusion depends on how well societies manage the transition, including giving workers a real voice.
- **Communities** can welcome newcomers, share knowledge and become the safety team that families left behind.

The message of this book is both: **do what you can, and work for conditions that let more people do it.**

Your place on someone else's team

There is one last thing, and it may be the most important.

You are not only someone who needs a safety team. You are also part of someone else's. Every newcomer who arrives in Vancouver after you will face what you faced. You know things they do not. You remember how it felt.

The Eduardo of Chapter 13, helping newcomers with their résumés on Sunday afternoons, is on someone's safety team. So is the Beatriz of Chapter 11, explaining Canadian finances in a church hall. So, perhaps, are you, or so you could be.

Helping others ride the wave is not only generous. It makes your own connections stronger, gives your life meaning beyond your job and reminds you of how far you have come.

Lab 14 — Your Safety Team

Time: about 45 minutes. **You need:** a sheet of paper.

Step 1 — Draw your team. Put yourself in the centre. Around you, write the names of the people in each layer: close crew, community, mentors, weak ties and family across distance.

Step 2 — Notice what each gives you. Next to each name, write how they help: learning, taking risks, recovering from setbacks, emotional support or opportunities.

Step 3 — Find the gap. Which layer is weakest? For many newcomers, it is mentors or weak ties.

Step 4 — One step outward. Choose one action this month to strengthen that layer: attend one event, ask one person for coffee, join one group. If it helps, ask AI to help you prepare what to say.

Step 5 — One step back. Write the name of one person who arrived after you and could use your help. Contact them this week.

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Gustavo's job came through a man he barely knew at a barbecue. Marcéu rose in the warehouse because people began to come to him. Every story in this book, if you look closely, has other people in it.

The wave is enormous. But you were never meant to ride it alone.

Conclusion — Evolving

A year later

A year after that grey February morning, Helena works for an infrastructure consultancy in Vancouver. Her title is not the one she had in Brazil. Her degree is still being assessed. But she leads a small team that combines her engineering experience with planning tools she taught herself, much of it with AI as her tutor and practice partner. She found the job through a woman she met at her daughter's school. Her children speak English better than she does, and they laugh at her accent. She laughs too. When people ask what she does, she no longer hesitates.

In São Paulo, Paulo's company has changed. Some of the work he used to do is now done mostly by AI. For a few months, he was frightened and angry. Then he made a decision. Instead of protecting what he knew, he began learning what the new tools could and could not do. He discovered that his twenty years of experience made him unusually good at catching the AI's mistakes, which younger colleagues missed. Today he leads quality review for the whole engineering department. The work is different. In some ways, he says, it is more interesting than before.

Neither of them returned to the safe harbour, because neither harbour still existed. **Both are in deep water now. And both are riding.**

Helena chose her wave. Paulo's was imposed. But by the end, both had done the same thing: they refused to be defined by the selves they had been, questioned them, discovered what those selves had been leaving out, and

chose what to do next. Neither simply bounced back to the old shape. Both grew.

What we have learned

The argument of this book has four moves.

We defend an incomplete understanding of who we are. There is no safe harbour for a career anymore, yet most of us hold on to a label that is only the top layer of who we are, and we hold on hardest when change is forced on us.

We can question it. Our own history, other people and AI each show us something the others miss, as long as we test what they suggest.

We can develop what we discover. Small bets, the courage to be a beginner, capability we build rather than borrow and creation in our own voice turn a discovery into something real.

And we remain responsible. For our own thinking and choices, for a life larger than any job, and for the people who ride with us and the ones who come after us.

None of this is guaranteed. Disruption opens a door; it does not walk us through it. What we do next, and who helps us, decides what we find on the other side.

Evolving

The title of this book is a single word: *Evolving*.

Evolving is not a single reinvention. You do not become someone new once and then stop. It is an ongoing practice: discovering who you are beneath the label, developing what you find and adapting again when the world changes, because it will. The AI wave is not the last wave. There will be others, perhaps larger and faster. The skills in this book are not for one wave. They are for all of them.

Which brings us back to the principle that has guided every chapter:

We should not allow what we have already become to determine everything we might become.

What you have become is real and valuable: your experience, your skills, the life you have built and the journey that brought you here. Nothing in this book asks you to throw it away. But it is not the limit of who you can be. Marcéu discovered that in a warehouse. Nathalia discovered it designing a bakery's website. Beatriz discovered it in a church hall. Helena and Paulo discovered it in deep water.

You can discover it too.

Final Lab — Your Evolving Plan

Time: about one hour. **You need:** your notebook from the earlier labs, and one sheet of paper.

This lab brings together everything you have discovered. Fill in one page, and keep it somewhere you will see it.

	Your answer	From
Underneath my label, I am someone who...		Labs 2 and 4
What I have been defending		Lab 3
My something more		Lab 4
The gifts I have discovered and tested		Labs 5, 6 and 7
My next small bet		Lab 8
One capability I will build, not borrow		Lab 10
A pillar I will strengthen		Lab 13
My safety team, and someone I will help		Lab 14
The next wave I want to be ready for		Your own judgment

Then add one sentence at the bottom of the page, in your own words: *"When the next wave comes, I will..."*

Return to this page every few months. Change it as you change. That is what evolving means.

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Dawn

If you go to a surf beach early in the morning, before the crowds, you will sometimes see a single surfer standing at the edge of the water.

The ocean is grey and restless. The waves are large, larger than yesterday. Nobody can promise what the sea will do today.

The surfer watches for a while, reading the water. Then she tightens the strap on her ankle, picks up her board and walks into the cold. She lies down on the board and begins to paddle, out through the white water, toward the place where the waves rise.

She is not going because the sea is safe.

She is going because she is ready.

Whatever wave comes next, may you meet it the same way: with everything you are, and everything you are still becoming.

About the Author



Ron Taylor is a Canadian communication consultant with three decades of experience teaching English through individual, personalized lessons. Over the years he has taught students from around the world; today he works exclusively with Brazilian professionals building careers and lives in Canada.

His lessons are all one-on-one and online. They cover job interviews, networking, the everyday English of Canadian workplaces and the confidence to be a beginner again.

He is the founder of Executive Class, a private communication consulting practice for Brazilian professionals in Canada, and the author of a library of free ebooks, including *The Brazucan Pathway*, *The Canadian Networking Code*, *The Brazilian Edge*, *Executive Class* and *52 Hours to a Winning Interview*.

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